

Don't Judge Citizens for Changing Their Opinions

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Abstract

Citizens change their minds about policy issues frequently, and scholars have long worried that this distorts democratic representation: Unstable opinions are assumed to be superficial or detached from citizens' core values and, thus, imply that citizens routinely support policies at odds with what they actually value. I challenge this reasoning. Using panel data from three countries ($n > 29,000$), I show that value-consistent opinions are only slightly more stable than value-inconsistent ones. Knowing an opinion is stable raises the probability that it is value-consistent by no more than six percentage points. I also argue that this result is theoretically expected: Staying true to one's values can require changing one's opinion, while value-inconsistent opinions can be stabilized by bias or conformity. In short, a dominant indictment of citizen competence and democratic representation—that opinion instability reveals the absence of meaningful preferences—rests on an assumption that does not hold.

Can citizens’ policy opinions provide meaningful guidance to policymakers? Many political scientists fear that the answer is no. While citizens often voice opinions about public policies, these opinions fluctuate unpredictably. This has led scholars to conclude they are superficial (Converse 1964) and unreliable indicators of what citizens truly value (Zaller 1992). In this view, an opinion’s over-time stability signals whether it reflects a citizen’s deeply held values (Peffley and Hurwitz 1993). And because most citizens’ opinions are unstable on most issues, the implication is that most policy opinions are meaningless.

This argument carries gloomy implications for democratic representation. Across the world, citizens vote directly on consequential policy referendums (e.g., Brexit), and their policy opinions strongly shape the political candidates they support (Ansolabehere, Rodden and Snyder 2008; Mummolo, Peterson and Westwood 2021). If citizens’ policy opinions are unstable over time—and thus a faint simulacrum of their values—citizens may commonly vote for policies and political candidates at odds with those values (e.g., Lau and Redlawsk 1997). As Achen (1975) warned, if citizens lack preferences that meaningfully reflect their values, “democratic theory loses its starting point” (1220).

Yet, despite decades of research debating how frequently citizens’ policy opinions change (Ansolabehere, Rodden and Snyder 2008; Converse 1964), almost no study has tested the assumption motivating this debate: that an opinion’s stability indicates whether it is value-consistent. If this assumption fails, that literature loses its normative grounding, and a primary argument against citizen competence falls with it.

I challenge this foundational assumption in two steps. First, I empirically examine whether value-consistent opinions are substantially more stable. Within high-quality panel datasets from Germany, the Netherlands, and the United States ($n > 29,000$), I identify pairs of basic values and policy issues wherein the value (e.g., concern for others) entails a particular opinion about the issue (e.g., support for welfare). I find that citizens whose opinions align with their values are nearly as likely to change their minds as those whose opinions do not, making stability nearly uninformative as a proxy for value-consistency. Second, I explain this result by arguing that, theoretically, stability *should* be a poor proxy for value-consistency: There are many reasons a citizen might hold onto a value-inconsistent opinion, and staying value-consistent can itself require changing one’s opinion as circum-

stances change.

These findings carry broad implications. If stability fails as a proxy for value-consistency, then decades of research on how often citizens change their minds tells us far less about democratic competence than has been assumed—and a central pillar of skepticism about citizen capacity gives way. The field also needs new tools: rather than asking *how often* citizens’ opinions change, scholars should ask *what* changes them and *why*.

Why Worry About Opinion Stability?

For six decades, political scientists have wrestled with a seemingly simple question: How often do citizens change their minds about policy issues? This debate began in 1964 with Converse’s “black and white” model, which provocatively suggested that large swaths of the public hold meaningless opinions that shift at random over time. Eleven years later, Achen (1975) retorted that much of the apparent change in citizens’ policy opinions could be attributed to measurement error from ambiguous survey questions, and correcting for this measurement error reveals citizens’ policy opinions to be much more stable. Subsequently, wave after wave of researchers—armed with better data, newer models, and softer assumptions—have tried to decompose true opinion change from mere statistical noise, each arriving at a different balance (Ansolabehere, Rodden and Snyder 2008; Erikson 1979; Feldman 1989; Hill 2001; Lauderdale, Hanretty and Vivyan 2018; Zaller and Feldman 1992).

But why has opinion stability received so much attention? It is not because stability is necessarily important in itself.¹ Instead, scholars primarily care about whether citizens’ policy opinions reflect their deeply held *values*—their core beliefs about right and wrong—which are thought to constitute the basis of meaningful opinions (Peffley and Hurwitz 1993; Rokeach 1973). Stability matters because it is taken to signal such value-consistency. Indeed, this assumption can be seen in the very first study of opinion stability: In his seminal article,

¹That said, one might argue that stability signals which opinions have political influence: A policy opinion can shape a citizen’s political behavior only if it persists over time (Luttrell and Togans 2021). Another perspective is that the more durable citizens’ policy opinions are, the easier it becomes for policymakers to represent them. Yet, while individual policy opinions may be unstable, the percentage of citizens who support a specific policy is usually more stable (Page and Shapiro 1992). Furthermore, it is unclear how valuable a stable opinion is if it persistently fails to reflect what a citizen truly values.

Converse (1964) argued that, if a policy opinion fluctuates over time, it is “*prima facie* evidence” (47) that the opinion is unconstrained by “some superordinate value or posture toward man and society” (7). Instead, unstable opinions represent “non-attitudes” invented on the spot to satisfy researchers (Converse 1964) or half-baked expressions of whatever considerations happened to be top-of-mind at the moment a question was asked (Zaller 1992). As shown in Table 1, similar ideas continue to motivate scholars’ interest in how much citizens’ opinions change over time.

Table 1: Assumed Relationship Between Stability and Value-Consistency

Quote	Source
“Another likely reason for the enhanced stability of important policy attitudes is linkage between these attitudes and core values.”	Krosnick (1990, 68)
“[G]eneral orientations—under most conditions—should be fairly stable. And if these beliefs structure more specific attitudes... orientations like militarism may provide the very stabilizing ‘anchors’ to policy attitudes...”	Peffley and Hurwitz (1993, 63)
“[T]he ease with which [citizens] can be blown from one side of an issue to the other suggests that the positions they take are far from securely anchored in underlying, enduring principles.”	Sniderman and Theriault (2004, 113–114)
“Political scientists commonly distinguish issues that are moral from ones that are not. The distinction is taken to be important for understanding persuadability, the stability of opinions...”	Ryan (2014, 380)
“[T]he more people moralize an attitude, the less they tend to change that attitude in response to persuasive arguments...”	Luttrell and Togan (2021, 552)
“Central components of belief systems should have a greater impact on other components, and therefore, these central components should keep other attitudes stable.”	Turner-Zwinkels and Brandt (2023, 2)

The assumption that an opinion’s stability tracks its value-consistency rests on a simple logic. Citizens possess general ideals—discrete values, if not integrated systems of values (e.g., ideologies)²—that can influence their political opinions (Feldman 2003; Zaller 1992). When citizens recognize that a policy debate relates to their values, they adopt or switch to

²Downs (1957) defines an ideology as “a verbal image of the good society and of the chief means of constructing such a society,” (96).

an opinion that matches their values to maintain consistency among their various attitudes (Festinger 1962). And because values are relatively stable over time (Milfont, Milojev and Sibley 2016; Vecchione et al. 2016, 2020), opinions anchored to these values should also be stable. Indeed, Converse (1964) expected value-consistent opinions to be *much* more stable. Ordinary citizens, he argued, lack policy opinions “constrained” by their “crowning principles.” Consequently, only 65% manage to “locate themselves even on the same side of a controversy” after two years (45). By contrast, he expected legislators’ opinions to exhibit far greater stability, precisely because their opinions should be more value-consistent. Indeed, he inferred that 90% would hold the same policy stance after two years (45).

To be sure, opinion stability is not the only way scholars have judged value-consistency. Sometimes, scholars measure value-consistency by directly comparing citizens’ opinions to their stated values, checking for inconsistencies (for a review, see Feldman 2003). Often, however, scholars lack data on citizens’ values and instead rely on opinion stability to infer whether opinions are value-consistent (e.g., Ansolabehere, Rodden and Snyder 2008; Converse 1964).

If stable opinions reflect genuine value commitments rather than shallow responses, then opinion stability becomes an important indicator of the quality of democratic representation. Many agree it is desirable for governments to enact policies that reflect citizens’ values (Mansbridge 1983; Miller and Stokes 1963; Price and Neijens 1997). This requires citizens to understand which policies advance their values—to recognize, for instance, that support for progressive taxation follows from a commitment to equality. Without that ability, citizens cannot vote for referendums or candidates that uphold their values (Ansolabehere, Rodden and Snyder 2008; Mummolo, Peterson and Westwood 2021), leaving democracy without a rudder to steer it toward outcomes that are valuable to citizens.

Does Opinion Stability Signal Value-Consistency?

While more than 60 years of studies have measured the stability of citizens’ opinions, only one has empirically examined the relationship between opinion stability and value-consistency (Peffley and Hurwitz 1993). That study, however, surveyed just 301 residents of a single

U.S. city, tracking only foreign policy attitudes over one year—limiting its generalizability. Moreover, the authors focused on political values which, as I discuss later, may not be exogenous to citizens’ partisanship or policy opinions (Goren 2005; Goren, Federico and Kittilson 2009).

The remaining evidence for the stability-consistency link is indirect and mixed. Some studies suggest that politically knowledgeable citizens hold more stable opinions (Converse and Pierce 1986; Converse 2000; Dean and Moran 1977; Delli Carpini and Keeter 1996; Feldman 1989; Jennings 1992; Kinder and Kalmoe 2017), while others find little difference (Achen 1975; Ansolabehere, Rodden and Snyder 2008; Erikson 1979). Even where knowledgeable citizens’ opinions are more stable, it is unclear *why*. One possibility is that knowledgeable citizens are more likely to form value-consistent opinions (Zaller 1992). This difference, however, is easily explained by another fact—namely, that knowledgeable citizens are better at motivated reasoning (Bakker, Lelkes and Malka 2020; Taber and Lodge 2006). In other words, knowledgeable citizens may have more stable opinions because they are better at defending their views, regardless of whether those views actually align with their values.

A separate line of research links opinion stability to self-reported characteristics that might accompany value-consistent opinions. Krosnick (1988; 1990) finds that stability correlates positively with issue importance—how much a citizen cares about a policy issue—which he partly attributes to “the linkage between these attitudes and core values” (Krosnick 1990, 68). However, when examining a wider range of panel datasets, Leeper (2014) finds this relationship to be small and statistically unreliable. Similarly, Luttrell and Togans (2021) finds a correlation between stability and moral conviction—the sense that an opinion reflects one’s notions of right and wrong—though this relationship is also small. This is perhaps because people are unreliable reporters of why they hold their opinions (for a review, see Pronin 2009). Many citizens may misunderstand how their values should inform their policy positions (Zaller 1992) or be influenced by their values without knowing it (Jost 2021). The fact that a citizen perceives an opinion as value-consistent does not mean it is.

In sum, despite six decades of research, the assumption that stability can be used to gauge value-consistency rests on surprisingly thin empirical ground. Ideally, the stability-consistency link would be adjudicated with direct empirical tests. That is the goal of this

article.

Which Opinions Are Value-Consistent?

To test whether opinion stability is related to its value-consistency, one first needs a way to identify which opinions reflect citizens’ deeper values. The most direct approach compares citizens’ opinions to their stated values (for a review, see Feldman 2003).³ For instance, scholars might compare citizens’ endorsements of statements such as “It is very important to you to help the people around you” with their opinions on welfare policies (e.g., Goren et al. 2016).

Importantly, political scientists distinguish between political and basic values. *Political* values are narrower, representing “principles and belief assumptions about government, citizenship, and American society” (McCann 1997, 565). For example, “militarism” captures whether a citizen prefers an assertive military posture or a more accommodating, diplomatic one and predicts opinions on issues like defense spending (Peffley and Hurwitz 1993). However, because political values closely resemble the opinions they are meant to explain, some scholars question whether they are distinct from, or exogenous to, policy opinions (Arceneaux et al. 2024). Rather than shaping policy opinions, these values may simply summarize citizens’ views within a particular domain. Indeed, citizens’ political values are roughly as unstable as their policy opinions (see Online Appendix I) and just as susceptible to elite influence (Goren 2005; Goren, Federico and Kittilson 2009; Vecchione et al. 2013). Any observed relationship between political values and policy opinions could therefore reflect reverse causation or a common cause like partisanship.

³Another popular strategy treats opinions as value-consistent when they match citizens’ self-reported ideology—e.g., when a “conservative” opposes universal healthcare or when a “progressive” supports it (Kinder and Kalmoe 2017; Groenendyk, Kimbrough and Pickup 2022). However, this approach faces two problems. First, many citizens misunderstand what terms such as “conservative” and “progressive” mean (Ellis and Stimson 2012). Thus, identifying with either label might not provide a strong signal about a citizen’s underlying values (c.f. Goren, Motta and Smith 2020). Second, ideological self-labels may function less as value summaries than as group identities to which citizens are emotionally attached. Indeed, self-identified conservatives (or progressives) are prone to endorse *any* policy that is labeled conservative (or progressive), regardless of the actual substance of those policies (Malka and Lelkes 2010).

Table 2: Higher-Order Values from Schwartz et al. (2012)

Focus	Name	Description
Social	Self-Transcendence	Prioritizes the well-being of others, especially those different than themselves, and the natural environment. Expressed through universalism and benevolence, this value directs behavior toward collective welfare rather than individual advantage.
	Conservation	Emphasizes stability, order, and continuity. Rooted in security, conformity, and tradition, it favors self-restraint and preservation of existing arrangements over rapid change.
Personal	Self-Enhancement	Centers on personal success, status, and control over resources or people. Linked to power and achievement, it advances self-interest even when in tension with the needs of others.
	Openness to Change	Values independence, novelty, and variety. Grounded in self-direction, stimulation, and hedonism, it encourages freedom, exploration, and the pursuit of new experiences.

For these reasons, recent work has focused on basic values (e.g., Goren et al. 2016). The most widely used psychological framework identifies four higher-order values fundamental to people’s moral outlooks (see Table 2; (Schwartz et al. 2012)). Of particular interest to political scientists are the two social values: self-transcendence and conservation. Self-transcendence captures a person’s concern for the welfare of others, especially those different from them. Conservation captures a desire for safe and predictable surroundings—for physical safety, social order, and the preservation of cultural customs. These values deserve special attention because they dictate how one relates socially to others (Schwartz 2012, 13–14), and citizens tend to form policy opinions based on what they think is best for society as a whole (Kinder and Kiewiet 1981; Sears and Funk 1991).⁴

Basic values also subsume the political values, strongly predicting those studied most in public opinion research—e.g., moral traditionalism, limited government, and equality (Schwartz et al. 2014). They also predict citizens’ policy opinions across a wide range of domains (see the print appendix). For instance, self-transcendence predicts support for

⁴Indeed, Goren et al. (2016) finds that the effect of “personally focused” values on policy opinions is weaker and less consistent. Relatedly, many studies have examined the effect of self-interest on citizens’ policy opinions. These studies find that self-interest has a substantial influence on citizens’ policy opinions in some circumstances—e.g., when one’s personal stakes in an issue are obvious and large (Horowitz and Levendusky 2011). However, most citizens do not have a clear and substantial self-interest in the resolution of many policy issues (for a review, see Sears and Funk 1991).

economic redistribution, racial equality, immigration, and civil liberties (e.g., Goren et al. 2016). By contrast, conservatism predicts support for strict crime policies and military interventions as well as opposition to immigration, racial equality measures, and progressive social policies like gay marriage (ibid.). These relationships are remarkably consistent across political cultures, suggesting that values and policy opinions are naturally aligned.

Unlike political values, basic values are plausibly exogenous to both partisanship and policy opinions (Vecchione et al. 2013). They transcend politics, guiding people’s attitudes and behaviors across all domains of life (Sagiv et al. 2017; Schwartz et al. 2012). They develop earlier than policy opinions—emerging by age eleven, before most political socialization occurs (Brown et al. 2023; Collins et al. 2017; Döring et al. 2015; Lee et al. 2017). Finally, they are quite stable over long periods (Milfont, Milojev and Sibley 2016; Vecchione et al. 2016, 2020) and considerably more stable than policy opinions (see Online Appendix J). In sum, basic values capture the substance of political value constructs while offering stronger guarantees of exogeneity.

Methods

To test whether value-consistent opinions are more stable over time, I use three panel datasets from Germany, the Netherlands, and the United States (summarized in Table 3).⁵ These countries were selected because they have high-quality panels with measures of basic values and many related policy opinions. Both the Dutch and U.S. panels use probability-based sampling designs, and the German panel combines quota-matched online samples with probability samples. The three countries also differ in ways that are potentially important. The United States has two major parties, which may make the mapping from values to opinions relatively simple (Levendusky 2010). Germany and the Netherlands have fragmented multi-party systems and coalition governments, which may complicate that mapping (Brader, Tucker and Duell 2013).

⁵These datasets are the German Longitudinal Election Study (GLES), the Longitudinal Internet studies for the Social Sciences (LISS) managed by the non-profit research institute Centerdata (Tilburg University, the Netherlands), and the General Social Survey’s 2008–2012 panel (GLES 2023; Scherpenzeel and Das 2010; Smith et al. 2018).

Table 3: Panel Datasets Used in Analysis

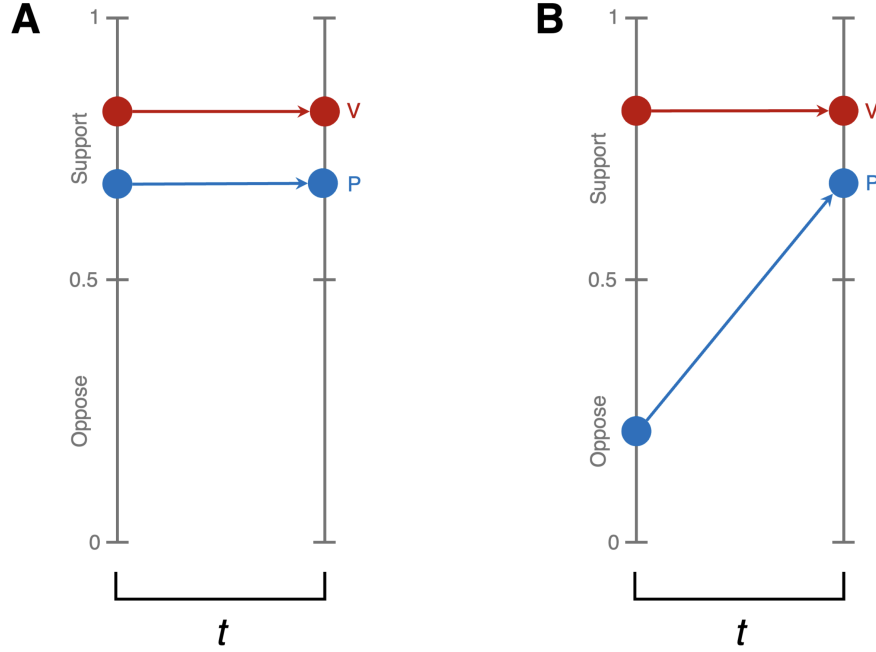
Country	Panelists	Policies	Waves	Period Lengths	Panel Length
Germany	26,682	51	22	$\bar{x} = 1.6$ years; $s = 1.39$	Oct. 2016 – Dec. 2021
Netherlands	1,674	17	10	$\bar{x} = 4.2$ years; $s = 2.57$	Dec. 2012 – Jan. 2024
United States	1,289	77	3	$\bar{x} = 2.6$ years; $s = 0.93$	April 2008 – Aug. 2012

To test whether value-consistent opinions are more stable over time, I leverage a straightforward expectation: Opinions that align with a citizen’s values in one wave should change less when measured again in the next. For illustration, imagine some time period t . At the beginning and end of t , we observe a value and opinions about a related policy issue. In one scenario, depicted in the left panel of Figure 1, a citizen’s policy opinion (in blue) is highly consistent with a related value (in red). In this scenario, we would expect the individual’s policy opinion to change little over period t . In another scenario, depicted in the right panel of Figure 1, the citizen’s opinion is less consistent with the value. In this scenario, an individual’s policy opinion should change more over period t . This is the intuition that I will test in my empirical models. I restructure my panel datasets so that each row captures a panelist’s (i) attitudes toward a particular policy issue (p) and value (v) over a specific period (t), where each period represents a pair of waves (e.g., $t = w_1 \rightarrow w_2$). Then, I examine whether citizens who hold value-consistent opinions at the beginning of a period are less likely to change their opinions by the end of that period. Observations from different panelists, values, policies, and periods are stacked atop one another, and I use fixed effects to control for differences across cases (see “Statistical Models” below).

Measurement

In each panel, I measure self-transcendence ($\alpha = .65 - .78$) and conservation ($\alpha = .59 - .73$) values by averaging items from a well-validated measure (Schwartz et al. 2001). Question wordings are in the Online Appendix C. All three datasets used in my main analysis measure each panelist’s values once, at the panel’s beginning (Germany and the Netherlands) or end

Figure 1: Empirical Expectations



Note: A stylistic depiction of my empirical expectations. The red points represent the a panelist's position on a value at the beginning and end of period t . The blue points represent the same panelist's position on a related policy opinion at the beginning and end of period t .

(United States). Consistent with past research, I assume that panelists' basic values remain stable throughout the panel (Milfont, Milojev and Sibley 2016; Vecchione et al. 2016, 2020).⁶ I validate this assumption in Online Appendix J, where I use an additional panel dataset to show that basic values are quite stable over time, especially when compared to most policy opinions. I also run robustness checks in Online Appendix K and Online Appendix L to confirm that value change does not bias my results.

For ease of interpretation, I measure value-consistency with a binary indicator equal to 1 if a citizen's opinion falls on the value-consistent side of a Likert policy scale and 0 otherwise. For instance, consider this item from the Dutch panel:

"It should be made easier to obtain asylum in the Netherlands." (Answers: Fully disagree, disagree, neither agree nor disagree, agree, and fully agree)

A citizen high in self-transcendence—that is, someone with strong concern for the wel-

⁶In the U.S. panel, political interest is also measured once. Thus, I assume that political interest is stable across that panel (Prior 2019).

fare of others—would be coded as value-consistent if they supported the policy and value-inconsistent if they opposed it or were ambivalent. I matched values to policy opinions based on a systematic review of existing research, considering only relationships that appear consistently across studies (see the print appendix for results and Online Appendix D for procedural details). In Online Appendix F, I also replicate my analyses using a purely empirical approach—regressing policy opinions on basic values to determine what goes with what—and find substantively similar results. To ensure comparability across items, I limit my main analyses to five- to seven-point Likert scales, though I replicate my analyses with all items in Online Appendix E. I also excluded retrospective evaluations of a past government’s performance (e.g., Did the government do an acceptable job on X issue?), which capture satisfaction with specific actors rather than policy opinions strictly.

I code opinion stability two ways, again for ease of interpretation. The first measure equals 1 if a citizen gave the exact same response at both waves of a period and 0 otherwise. For instance, consider the asylum item again: A panelist who fully agreed with this item at the start and end of period t would be coded 1. Any change—even from fully agreed to agreed—would be coded 0. This is the simplest measure of test-retest reliability, but exact-match coding is strict: Minor fluctuations register as instability, potentially attenuating true differences between value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions. The second measure is therefore more lenient. It equals 1 if a citizen remained on the same side of the policy scale across both waves and 0 if they crossed to the other side or became ambivalent. For example, a panelist who moved from fully agreed to agreed would still be coded 1; one who became ambivalent or came to disagree would be coded 0.

Statistical Models

To estimate the relationship between opinion stability and value-consistency, for each panel dataset, I ran an OLS⁷ regression of the following form:

$$OpinionStable_{i,p,t} = \beta_1 * ValueConsistent_{i,p,v,t} + \beta * Traits_{i,t} + \alpha_{p,v} + \delta_{s,p,t} + \epsilon$$

In this model, *OpinionStable* indicates whether panelist i maintained a stable opinion on

⁷Logit models produce qualitatively similar results (see Online Appendix B).

policy issue p over period t . The primary independent variable, *ValueConsistent*, captures whether that opinion aligned with a specific value v at the start of the period. *Traits* is a matrix of subject-level controls that includes a panelist’s education, political interest, and age at the beginning of the period. Per convention among values researchers, this vector also includes a term that captures a subject’s tendency to acquiesce to all value statements, regardless of their content (Schwartz 1992). This last term serves two purposes. First, it helps minimize measurement error in *ValueConsistent*. Second, those prone to acquiescence bias may also be less stable in their opinions.

To account for unobserved heterogeneity, the model incorporates two layers of fixed effects. First, “case” fixed effects (α) represent specific value-policy pairings. These ensure the model compares value-consistency and stability only within a given value-policy pairing. Second, “trend” fixed effects (δ) account for the initial stance (s) held on a policy issue (e.g., left, center, or right) during period t . This term accounts for the possibility that certain positions may be more unstable in general or during specific timeframes. For instance, moderate positions may be more unstable in general, and conservative stances on government intervention may have been more volatile following the 2008 financial crisis. They also control for differences in the length of time between panelists’ responses.

This modeling approach has several advantages. First, it allows me to estimate a single coefficient (β_1) that represents a general tendency for value-consistent opinions to be more stable over time. Second, running a regression, rather than looking at simple inter-wave correlations, allows me to control for other potential causes of opinion stability. Third, by construction, my dependent variable is always measured months after my independent variables. This alleviates concerns about reverse causality.

Before turning to the analysis, I offer a brief note on evidentiary burden. As noted above, scholars care about stable opinions largely because they are presumed to be causally downstream of citizens’ values. For this reason, I have taken several steps to strengthen the case that my key independent variable (value-consistency) causes my dependent variable (opinion stability). Still, establishing causality with panel data is difficult, since unobserved confounders remain a concern. The goals of this article, however, are more pragmatic: Rather than offering definitive proof of causality, I ask whether the best available data are consistent

with a world in which stability and value-consistency reliably *predict* one another. If the evidence for such a relationship proves underwhelming, that alone should caution scholars against treating stability as a gauge of value-consistency.

Main Results

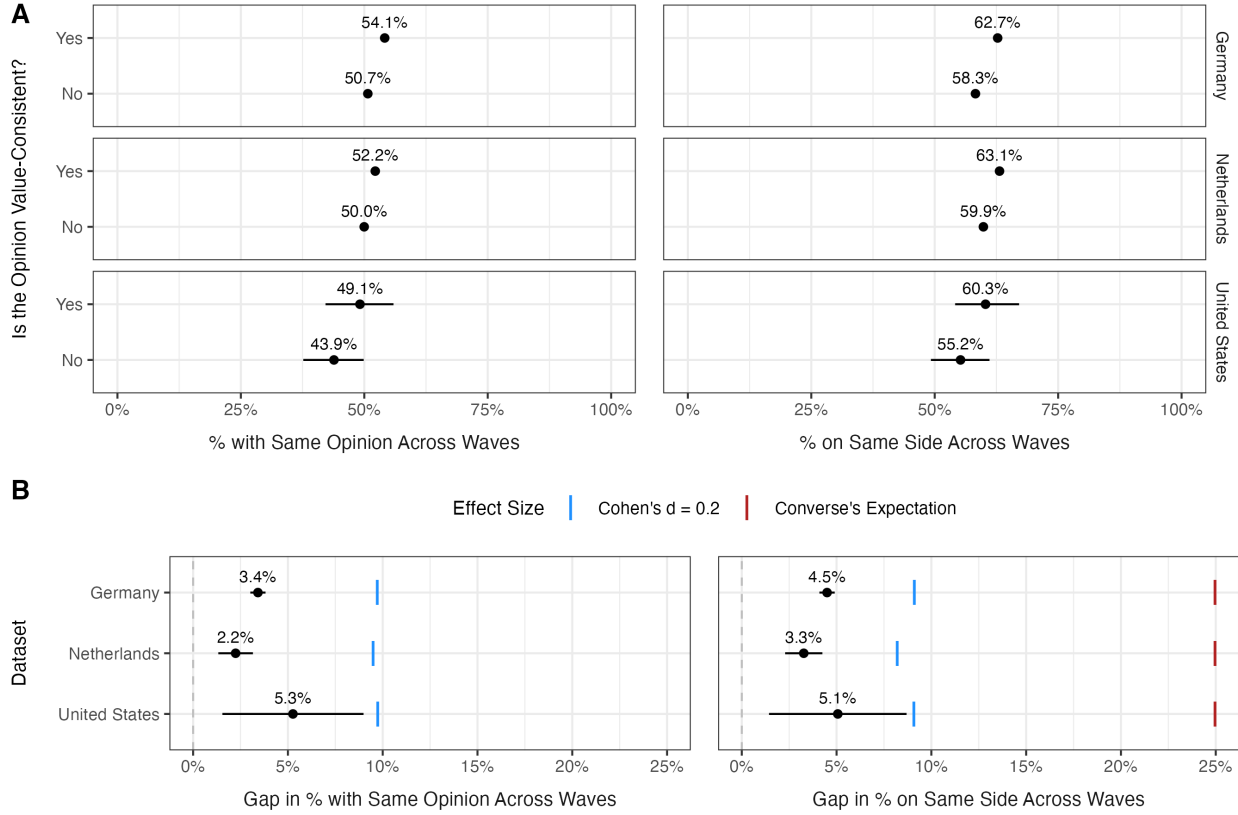
Sub-figure A of Figure 2 plots the predicted stability of value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions—averaged across policy issues, values, and periods. It shows the percentage of respondents who expressed the exact same opinion across waves (left) and the percentage who remained on the same side of a policy scale across waves (right). Sub-figure B of Figure 2 plots the gap between these estimates relative to two benchmarks: what would traditionally be considered a small effect (*Cohen's* $d \leq 0.2$) and the gap that Converse (1964) expected to see between citizens and legislators.

As seen on the left side of Figure 2, panelists are only slightly more likely to hold on to value-consistent than -inconsistent opinions. This is true across all three panel datasets. For instance, in the U.S. panel, 43.9% (95% CI 37.6–49.9) of panelists who voiced a value-inconsistent opinion at one wave voiced the exact same opinion at the next. By contrast, 49.1% (95% CI 42.1–55.9) of panelists who voiced a value-consistent opinion at one wave voiced the same opinion at the next wave, an increase of roughly five percentage points ($p < .01$). Across all three panel datasets, the upper bound of the 95% confidence interval is less than what would traditionally be considered a small effect size (*Cohen's* $d \leq 0.2$).

The right side of Figure 2 tells a similar story. In the U.S. panel, 55.2% (95% CI 49.2–61.1) of panelists with a value-inconsistent opinion remained on the same side of a policy scale across waves, compared to 60.3% (95% CI 54.1–67.1) of those with a value-consistent opinion. This gap of 5.1 percentage points is statistically significant but substantively small ($p < .01$). The stability gap between value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions is even smaller in the German and Dutch panels, at 4.5 and 3.3 percentage points respectively ($p < .001$ in both cases). Again, the upper bound of every 95% confidence interval falls below the threshold for a small effect size (*Cohen's* $d \leq 0.2$).

These gaps are especially modest relative to Converse's expectations. Recall that Con-

Figure 2: Relative Stability of Value-Consistent and -Inconsistent Policy Opinions



Note: Sub-figure A shows the predicted stability of value-consistent and value-inconsistent opinions—averaged across policy issues, values, and periods. The left column shows the percentage of respondents who expressed the exact same opinion across waves; the right column shows the percentage who remained on the same side of a policy scale across waves. Sub-figure B visualizes the gap between these estimates alongside two benchmarks: Cohen's $d = 0.2$ (blue) and Converse's expected gap between citizens and legislators (red). Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist. Data weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight.

verse (1964) found that roughly 65% of ordinary citizens stayed on the same side of a policy issue over two years. By contrast, he expected about 90% of legislators to do so, precisely because their opinions should be “constrained” by their values. The gaps observed here are, at most, one fifth of that 25-percentage-point difference. Importantly, Converse examined opinion stability over two years, and the average period lengths in the panel datasets straddle this benchmark ($\bar{x}_{DE} = 1.6$ years; $\bar{x}_{NL} = 4.2$ years; $\bar{x}_{US} = 2.6$ years). In any case, while longer intervals between waves reduce average opinion stability, they do not widen the gap between value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions (see Online Appendix H).

These benchmarks establish that the stability gap between value-consistent and -

inconsistent opinions is small. But a separate question is whether even this small gap makes stability a useful proxy for value-consistency. For a proxy to be useful, observing it should substantially update one’s belief about the underlying quantity. How much does knowing an opinion is stable rather than unstable change the probability that it is value-consistent? Using the observed stability rates and the empirical base rate of value-consistent opinions in each sample, we can answer this question directly. Formally, let C denote that an opinion is value-consistent and S denote that it is stable. By Bayes’s theorem, the probability that an opinion is value-consistent given that it is stable is $P(C|S) = \frac{P(S|C) \times P(C)}{P(S)}$. Subtracting this quantity from $P(C|\neg S)$ across all three datasets, we see that stability shifts the probability that an opinion is value-consistent by no more than six percentage points.⁸ In other words, whether an opinion is stable tells us very little about whether it aligns with a citizen’s values.

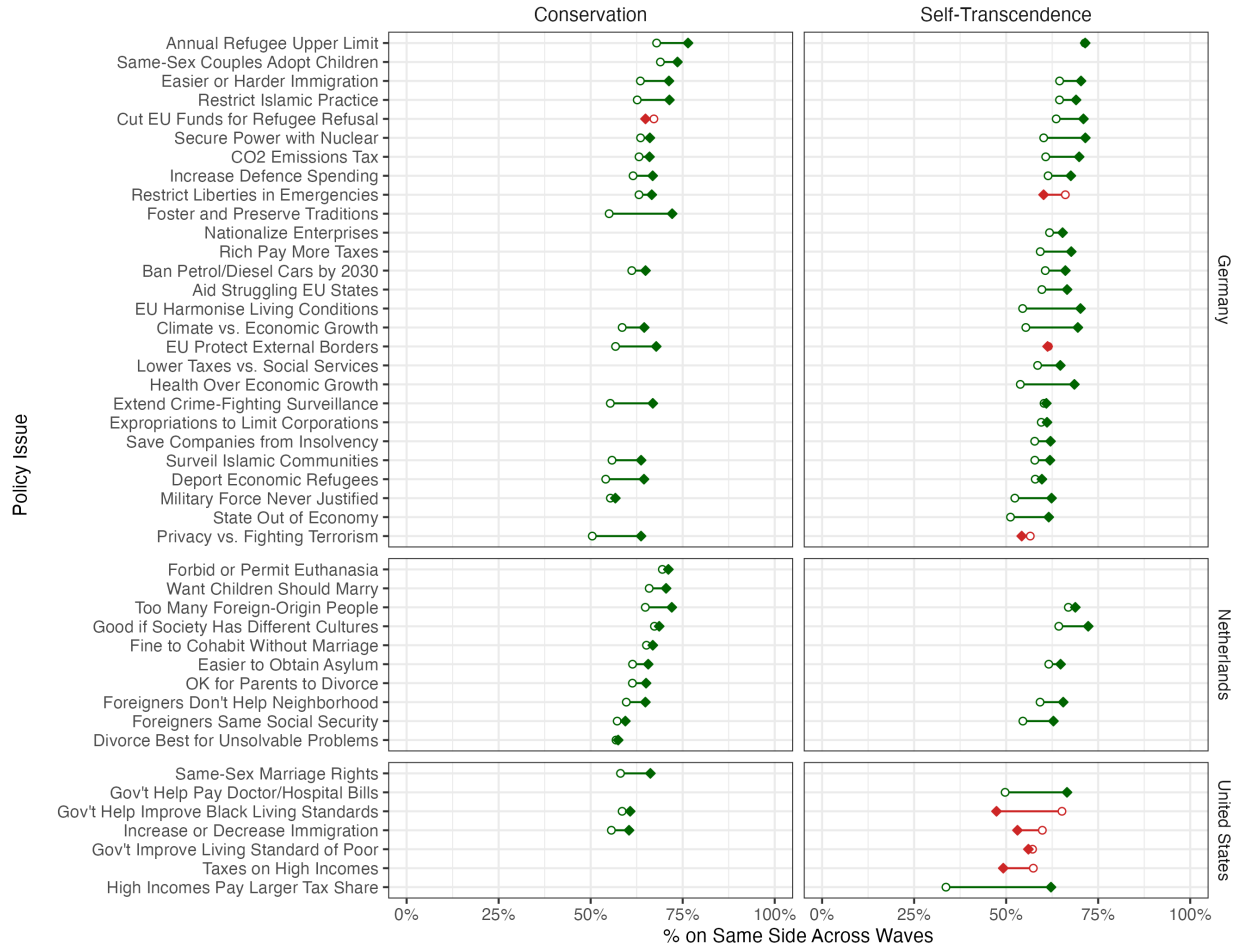
These average results, however, obscure notable differences across individual value-policy pairings. Figure 3 plots the predicted stability of value-consistent (filled diamonds) and -inconsistent (open circles) opinions for each case, broken out by value and dataset. Green lines indicate cases where value-consistent opinions are more stable; red lines indicate cases where the relationship reverses. (See Online Appendix G for model details.)

Two patterns stand out. First, while value-consistent opinions are more stable in most cases, the gap is typically small in the German and Dutch panels: The filled diamonds sit only slightly to the right of the open circles in the vast majority of cases. Second, in a notable minority of cases, value-consistent opinions are actually *less* stable than value-inconsistent ones. These reversals appear across both value types.

The U.S. panel tells a somewhat different story. When value-consistency is defined vis-à-vis self-transcendence, the gaps between value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions are larger and more often reversed in sign. The small average effect in the U.S. panel thus reflects larger positive and negative cases that cancel out, rather than a consistently weak relationship. This likely stems from the U.S. panel having fewer panelists and waves than the German and Dutch panels, making case-level estimates noisier. In the German and Dutch

⁸ $P(C|S) - P(C|\neg S)$ equals -.03, .01, and .06 in Germany, the Netherlands, and the United States respectively.

Figure 3: Heterogeneity by Case



Note: Predicted stability of value-consistent (filled diamonds) and -inconsistent (open circles) opinions for each case, broken out by value and dataset. Green lines indicate cases where value-consistent opinions are more stable; red lines indicate cases where the relationship reverses. Data weighted to give each panelist and period equal weight.

panels, by contrast, estimates are more precise, and the average effect is small because the case-level effects are themselves small.

Either way, opinion stability is a poor proxy for value-consistency: The relationship is too weak to be useful in the German and Dutch panels and too noisy to be reliable in the U.S. panel.

Supplementary Analyses

Thus far, the motivating assumption behind research on opinion stability has poor empirical support: Value-consistent opinions are only slightly more stable than value-inconsistent ones. Yet, small correlations may have various causes, such as measurement error. In the online appendices, I run several supplementary analyses to assess the robustness of my findings. I summarize these checks in Table 4 and briefly describe each check below.

Table 4: Supplementary Analyses

Concern	Analysis	O.A.
Measurement error may attenuate the consistency-stability relationship.	Compare stability of basic values and policy opinions.	J
	Test whether cross-sectional value-policy correlations shift over time.	K
	Subset to participants whose values are least likely to change.	L
	Construct indexes of policy opinions.	M
	Measure value-consistency and opinion stability as continuous variables.	N
Basic values may be unimportant or too removed from politics.	Subset to participants who most value self-transcendence (conservation).	O
	Subset to cases with the strongest cross-sectional value-policy correlations.	P
Citizens may be unaware of how their values and policy opinions align.	Subset to highly educated participants.	Q
	Subset to politically interested participants.	Q

Note: O.A. refers to the online appendix where an analysis resides.

Does Error Attenuate the Consistency-Stability Relationship?

A natural question is whether error in my value measurements attenuates the association between value-consistency and opinion stability. As noted above, all three datasets used in my analysis measure each panelist’s values once, at the panel’s beginning (Germany and the Netherlands) or end (United States). This design requires me to impute citizens’ values at

other waves. If values and policy opinions tend to drift in the same direction over time, this approach could weaken the estimated association between value-consistency and stability.

Several lines of evidence suggest it does not. Prior work shows that basic values remain stable for long periods, which suggests any measurement error is small (Milfont, Milojev and Sibley 2016; Vecchione et al. 2016, 2020). Using an additional German panel, I confirm that values fluctuate far less than most policy opinions (Online Appendix J). Online Appendix K tests a further implication: If values shifted, we should see the average cross-sectional association between values and policy opinions weaken as the value measurements grow stale. No such pattern emerges. Finally, results are similar when the analysis is limited to middle-aged panelists (Online Appendix L), who are least likely to exhibit value change (Milfont, Milojev and Sibley 2016).

Three further measurement checks reinforce my conclusions. First, re-running the analyses with policy-opinion indexes (Online Appendix M) guards against item-level measurement error (Ansolabehere, Rodden and Snyder 2008). The results are unchanged. Second, replacing binary indicators with continuous measures of value-consistency and opinion stability yields similarly modest effects (Online Appendix N). Third, extending the analysis to all available policy items—including shorter scales excluded from the main specification—produces comparable findings (Online Appendix E).

Are Basic Values Unimportant or Too Removed From Politics?

Although self-transcendence and conservation values are known to structure policy opinions (see the print appendix), the association could be diluted if these values are unimportant to some respondents. To test this, I calculate a standard measure of value importance: how strongly a respondent endorses a given value relative to their average endorsement of all other measured values (Schwartz et al. 2001).⁹ For each value-policy pairing, I then subset to respondents in the top third of value importance and re-estimate the relevant models. The results, shown in Online Appendix O, again indicate that the stability-consistency link is weak.

⁹That is, I calculate each participant’s average level of agreement with all basic values, not just self-transcendence and conservation values. Then, I subtract this cross-value average from the panelist’s ratings of self-transcendence and conservation values, respectively, and take the absolute value.

It is also possible that basic values are too removed from politics for the consistency-stability link to emerge. Restricting the analysis to value-policy pairs with the strongest cross-sectional associations (*Standardized* $\beta \geq .3$) does not substantively alter the findings (Online Appendix P).

Are Citizens Unaware of How Values and Policy Opinions Align?

Lastly, my measure of value-consistency may not isolate opinions formed through conscious, value-based reasoning. For some citizens, the alignment may be purely incidental. Given that policy knowledge tends to be low (e.g., Gilens 2001), many citizens may not recognize which opinions are consistent with their values (Zaller 1992), and the true consistency-stability link could be stronger among more politically knowledgeable individuals. To test this, in Online Appendix Q, I replicate my analyses among those panelists in the top third of education and political interest. The results show that the stability gap between value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions is similar in these subgroups, and the gap remains small in substantive terms. This suggests that even among more politically sophisticated citizens, opinion stability is a poor proxy for value-consistency.

Why Isn't the Consistency-Stability Link Stronger?

For 60 years, researchers have assumed that opinion stability signals whether an opinion meaningfully reflects a citizen's values and, by extension, whether citizens are competent and democratic representation is meaningful. And yet—across three countries, dozens of policy issues, and a wide range of robustness checks—there is simply no empirical evidence that whether an opinion is stable tells us much about whether it aligns with a citizen's values.

Why is the association between value-consistency and opinion stability so weak? The answer is that stability *should* be a poor proxy for value-consistency on theoretical grounds—even if values are consistently associated with policy opinions in cross-sectional data (see also the print appendix). Two arguments illustrate why.

First, staying value-consistent can require changing one's opinion. Consider a typical policy item from the German panel:

Germany's defence expenditure should be increased over the next few years.

At any given time, we would expect individuals higher in conservation values—those who care more about security, among other things—to express greater support for increased defense spending. And indeed, studies consistently find a positive cross-sectional association between conservation values and defense spending preferences across countries and contexts (e.g., Rathbun et al. 2016; Schwartz et al. 2014). But this association does not entail that value-consistent opinions about defense spending should remain fixed. If Germany had recently raised its defense budget substantially, further increases may seem unnecessary even to those who prioritize security, leading them to become ambivalent or even opposed. In such situations, opinion change is not only possible but *appropriate*. Experimental evidence supports this logic: Dias (2025) shows that citizens update their policy preferences when they learn that a policy embodies their values better or worse, holding all else equal. Opinion change, in other words, can reflect principled thinking rather than its absence.

As importantly, policy issues can connect to multiple values, and which connection seems relevant depends on how the issue is framed. When a policy engages competing values and both are salient, citizens side with the one they consider more important (Tetlock 1986). Consider a citizen who values both self-transcendence and conservation but considers the former more important. When a policy engages both values—say, expanding civil liberties at the expense of security—this citizen supports it, because self-transcendence matters more to them. But if media coverage frames the same policy purely in terms of security, civil liberties may drop out as a consideration. Now, the same citizen could oppose the policy—not because their values changed, but—because framing changed which values they saw as relevant. Brewer (2002) provides evidence for this kind of process, showing that media coverage can shape which values citizens bring to bear when evaluating policy. As the framing environment shifts over time—through media coverage, political debate, and campaign messaging—the values a citizen sees as relevant to a policy may shift too, and value-consistent thinking could lead them to change sides. These framing effects can be used strategically by politicians to win support for policies that citizens would reject given full information (Druckman 2001). But shifting frames can also reflect genuine changes in conditions. If a country faces real security threats while civil liberties are well-protected, emphasizing the security consequences

of a policy may be reasonable.

Second, value-inconsistent opinions can be stable if they are anchored by bias or conformity. Values are not the only force that can hold policy opinions in place (for a review, see Mintz, Valentino and Wayne 2021). Partisan loyalty, in particular, may be a powerful source of opinion stability (Freder, Lenz and Turney 2019; Elder and O’Brian 2022). Citizens often feel emotionally attached to their political parties (Huddy, Mason and Aarøe 2015), and this attachment can compel them to adopt and maintain the positions of party leaders (e.g., Bakker and Leles 2018). An abundance of experiments shows that citizens readily adopt or defend policy opinions, regardless of their ideological content, when their political party endorses them (for a review, see Bullock 2020). And under typical conditions—when citizens agree with their parties (Dalton 2017), parties rarely shift positions (Koedam 2022), and citizens rarely switch parties (Franklin and Jackson 1983)—partisan loyalty should make opinions stable over time, whether or not those opinions reflect the citizen’s values. Indeed, as Druckman, Fein and Leeper (2012) write, “[W]hen opinions display stability, it may reflect an underlying bias rather than considered opinions arrived at after deliberating over alternative perspectives,” (444).

Together, these two arguments would compress the stability gap from both sides. Value-consistent citizens may change their opinions as circumstances evolve, while value-inconsistent citizens may hold firm for reasons unrelated to values. If so, exactly the pattern observed above would emerge: a modest difference in stability between value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions, despite a clear cross-sectional link between values and policy preferences.

Conclusion

Research on the stability of citizens’ policy opinions represents some of the most thoughtful and empirically rigorous work in political science. Its foundational premise is straightforward: If an opinion is unstable, it is likely to be value-inconsistent. And if most citizens lack value-consistent opinions on most issues, it becomes doubtful that they can steer governments toward policies that reflect their values.

This article challenges that premise. Using panel data from three countries with very different party systems—a two-party system in the United States and fragmented multiparty systems in Germany and the Netherlands—I find that value-consistent opinions are only modestly more stable than value-inconsistent ones. Knowing that an opinion is stable raises the probability that it is value-consistent by no more than six percentage points. This result holds across a battery of robustness checks, including continuous measures, policy-opinion indexes, and subsets of politically sophisticated citizens. At the case level, the pattern is either consistently weak (Germany and the Netherlands) or too noisy to be informative (the United States). In short, stability is a poor proxy for value-consistency.

This finding is not merely an empirical curiosity—it is theoretically expected. Staying true to one’s values can require changing one’s opinion as circumstances and framing evolve, so opinion change may reflect careful reasoning rather than shallow thinking. And value-inconsistent opinions can be held in place by forces like partisan loyalty, so stability may reflect bias or conformity rather than conviction. The assumption linking stability to value-consistency is therefore not just unsupported by the data; it lacks a compelling theoretical rationale. This undercuts a central argument against citizen competence: If stability does not track value-consistency, then decades of research on how often citizens change their minds tells us little about whether their opinions reflect their values—or about the quality of democratic representation.

The question of whether citizens reason from their values remains open. Cross-sectional correlations between values and policy opinions give reason for cautious optimism (see the print appendix). Yet, direct comparisons between citizens’ values and opinions face their own challenges (Dias 2025). Citizens evaluate policies in light of many values, so an opinion that appears inconsistent with one value may be consistent with others the researcher did not measure. Moreover, when policies are described in abstract or hypothetical terms—as most survey items are—the relationship between a value and an opinion is often undefined, making low correlations difficult to interpret.

If scholars wish to evaluate whether citizens hold value-consistent opinions—and we should, if we care about democratic representation—we need better tools. Rather than asking *how often* citizens’ opinions change or whether opinions correlate with values cross-

sectionally, a more promising path is to ask whether citizens have the *skills* to form value-consistent opinions (Dias 2025; Druckman 2014). In particular, scholars can test whether citizens respond to specific policy characteristics—such as how a policy distributes benefits—in ways that reflect their values. This skills-based approach sidesteps the problems of both the stability and cross-sectional paradigms: It does not require stability to proxy for value-consistency, it does not require researchers to anticipate every relevant value, and it provides citizens with the information they need to bring their values to bear. Early evidence using this approach suggests that citizens do use policy information to form value-consistent opinions (Dias 2025), though much more work is needed.

For six decades, the instability of citizens’ opinions has been taken as evidence that democratic theory lacks a starting point. That verdict rests on an assumption that does not hold. We have been judging citizens by the wrong standard, and the indictment tells us more about the limits of our methods than about the capacities of citizens.

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Appendix: “Social” Values and Related Policy Opinions

Note: This table summarizes the literature on the relationship between self-transcendence and conservation values and policy opinions. The “S.T.” and “CON.” columns indicate whether the value is generally associated with support for stereotypically left-wing opinions, right-wing opinions, or a mix of both. For more details on how these pairings were identified, see Online Appendix D.

Policy Area	S.T.	CON.	Sources
Welfare, redistribution, and free enterprise (e.g., higher taxes on the rich)	Left	Mixed	Abdallah (2023); Arian and Sekercioglu (2019); Reinl et al. (2024); Schwartz, Caprara and Vecchione (2010); Schwartz et al. (2014); Wu and Molden (2024)
Environmental protection (e.g., CO ₂ taxes)	Left	Right	Abdallah (2023); Bergquist et al. (2022); Davidov and Meuleman (2012); Grunert and Juhl (1995); Milfont and Gouveia (2006); Nilsson, von Borgstede and Biel (2004); Oh, Hudson and Hudson (2025); Perlaviciute and Steg (2015); Schwartz (2012); Smith and Hempel (2022); Steg, Dreijerink and Abrahamse (2005); Steg et al. (2011); Stern et al. (1995); Stern, Dietz and Guagnano (1998)
Immigration	Left	Right	Abdallah (2023); Ahmadinia (2025); Cichocki and Jabkowski (2019); Davidov et al. (2008); Dennison, Davidov and Seddig (2020); Messing and Ságvári (2021); Miglietta, Tartaglia and Loera (2018); Schwartz (2007 <i>b</i>); Schwartz (2007 <i>a</i>); Schwartz, Caprara and Vecchione (2010); Schwartz et al. (2014); Seewann (2022)
International cooperation (e.g., EU membership)	Mixed	Mixed	Dennison, Seddig and Davidov (2021); Goren et al. (2016); Rathbun et al. (2016); Reinl et al. (2024)
Law, order, and civil liberties (e.g., limiting terrorism by restricting movement)	Left	Right	Schwartz, Caprara and Vecchione (2010); Schwartz et al. (2014)
Military interventions (e.g., defense spending)	Left	Right	Crawford, Wiley and Ventresco (2014); Goren et al. (2016); O'Dwyer and oymak (2020); Rathbun et al. (2016); Schwartz, Caprara and Vecchione (2010); Schwartz et al. (2014)
Nuclear power	Left	Right	Perlaviciute and Steg (2015); Whitfield et al. (2009)
Racial equality (e.g., aid to Black people)	Left	Right	Goren et al. (2016); Grigoryan and Schwartz (2021)

Policy Area	S.T.	CON.	Sources
Social mores (e.g., gay marriage)	Mixed	Right	Abdallah (2023); Dobewall and Rudnev (2014); Donaldson, Handren and Lac (2017); Goren et al. (2016); Kuntz et al. (2015); Schwartz (2012); Schwartz, Caprara and Vecchione (2010); Schwartz et al. (2014); Wu and Molden (2024)

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Appendix A: OLS Models

Table A1: OLS Models of Opinion Stability

	Germany		Netherlands		United States	
	Same Opinion	Same Side	Same Opinion	Same Side	Same Opinion	Same Side
Value-Consistent	0.034 (0.002)	0.045 (0.002)	0.022 (0.005)	0.033 (0.005)	0.053 (0.019)	0.051 (0.018)
Education	0.019 (0.004)	0.039 (0.004)	0.049 (0.013)	0.041 (0.012)	0.048 (0.031)	0.075 (0.029)
Political Interest	0.001 (0.005)	0.012 (0.005)	−0.003 (0.012)	0.026 (0.011)	0.019 (0.025)	0.019 (0.023)
Age	0.001 (0.000)	0.001 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.001 (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)
Acquiescence	−0.073 (0.011)	−0.046 (0.011)	−0.116 (0.029)	−0.060 (0.025)	−0.034 (0.076)	−0.053 (0.073)
Num.Obs.	10 231 703	10 231 703	768 551	768 551	11 160	11 160
RMSE	0.49	0.45	0.48	0.41	0.49	0.46

Note: This model includes case and trend fixed effects. Data weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight. Wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist in parentheses.

Appendix B: Logit Models

Table B1: Logit Models of Opinion Stability

	Germany		Netherlands		United States	
	Same Opinion	Same Side	Same Opinion	Same Side	Same Opinion	Same Side
Value-Consistent	0.147 (0.009)	0.228 (0.011)	0.103 (0.022)	0.236 (0.033)	0.226 (0.080)	0.262 (0.095)
Education	0.080 (0.018)	0.185 (0.020)	0.215 (0.059)	0.239 (0.068)	0.203 (0.129)	0.365 (0.146)
Political Interest	0.004 (0.021)	0.055 (0.023)	−0.010 (0.054)	0.158 (0.065)	0.080 (0.106)	0.092 (0.111)
Age	0.003 (0.000)	0.005 (0.000)	0.002 (0.001)	−0.002 (0.001)	0.005 (0.003)	0.004 (0.003)
Acquiescence	−0.311 (0.048)	−0.219 (0.051)	−0.513 (0.130)	−0.395 (0.142)	−0.147 (0.319)	−0.255 (0.353)
Num.Obs.	10 231 703	10 231 703	768 551	768 551	11 157	11 157
RMSE	0.49	0.45	0.48	0.41	0.49	0.46

Note: This model includes case and trend fixed effects. Data weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight. Standard errors clustered by panelist in parentheses.

Appendix C: Question Wordings

Germany

Parentheses contain questions' unique identifiers. Answer choices for Likert items sit beside their unscaled numerical values (i.e., the values these choices corresponded to before I rescaled variables to range between 0 and 1.)

Age (2290). Please enter the year you were born in. [TEXT BOX] *(To approximate age, the survey-wave year was subtracted from the panelist's birth year.)*

Education (2320). What's your highest level of general education?

1. Still at school
2. Finished school without school leaving certificate
3. Lowest formal qualification of Germany's tripartite secondary school system, after 8 or 9 years of schooling ("Hauptschulabschluss, Volksschulabschluss")
4. Intermediary secondary qualification, after 10 years of schooling ("Mittlere Reife, Realschulabschluss or Polytechnische Oberschule mit Abschluss 10. Klasse")
5. Certificate fulfilling entrance requirements to study at a polytechnical college/university of applied sciences ("Fachhochschulreife (Abschluss einer Fachoberschule etc.)")
6. Higher qualification, entitling holders to study at a university ("Abitur or Erweiterte Oberschule mit Abschluss 12. Klasse (Hochschulreife)")

Party Identification (2090). In Germany, many people lean towards a particular party for a long time, although they may occasionally vote for a different party. How about you, do you in general lean towards a particular party? If so, which one?

- CDU/CSU (Christlich Demokratische Union/ Christlich-Soziale Union)
- CDU (Christlich Demokratische Union)
- CSU (Christlich-Soziale Union)
- SPD (Sozialdemokratische Partei Deutschlands)
- FDP (Freie Demokratische Partei)
- Bündnis 90/Die Grünen

- Die Linke
- AfD (Alternative für Deutschland)
- Other party

Political Interest (010). Quite generally, how interested are you in politics?

1. Not interested at all
2. Not very interested
3. In between
4. Somewhat interested
5. Very interested

The value questions were introduced with the following text: “In what follows, several people are described on the basis of what is important to them. Please indicate how much each person is or is not like you.” All value questions were answered with a Likert scale that ranged from Not like me at all (1) to Very much like me (6).

Self-Transcendence Values ($\alpha = .78$)

- (3320c) He/she thinks it is important that every person in the world should be treated equally. He/she believes everyone should have equal opportunities in life.
- (3320h) It is important to him/her to listen to people who are different from him/her. Even when he/she disagrees with them, he/she still wants to understand them.
- (3320k) It is very important to him/her to help the people around him/her. He/she wants to care for their well-being.
- (3320p) It is important to him/her to be loyal to his/her friends. He/she wants to devote himself/herself to people close to him/her.
- (3320u) He/she strongly believes that people should care for nature. Looking after the environment is important to him/her.

Conservation Values ($\alpha = .69$)

- (3320e) It is important to him/her to live in secure surroundings. He/she avoids anything that might endanger his/her safety.

- (3320j) It is important to him/her to be humble and modest. He/she tries not to draw attention to himself/herself.
- (3320m) It is important to him/her that the government ensures his/her safety against all threats. He/she wants the state to be strong so it can defend its citizens.
- (3320n) It is important to him/her always to behave properly. He/she wants to avoid doing anything people would say is wrong.
- (3320t) It is important to the person to preserve the customs that he/she has learned. He/she thinks it is best to do things the traditional way.
- (3320q) He/she thinks people should follow rules at all times. He/she believes that people should do what they're told.

Table C1 depicts the policy items and whether my literature review tied that policy item to self-transcendence (S.T.) or conservation (CON.) values. Answer choices are omitted for brevity. These can be found here: https://search.gesis.org/research_data/ZA6838.

Table C1: Policy Items from German Longitudinal Election Study (GLES)

Policy Item	S.T.	CON.
(060b) The main business enterprises must be nationalized.	Yes	No
(060e) Under certain circumstances, a dictatorship is the better form of government.	No	No
(060k) Traditions should definitely be fostered and preserved.	No	Yes
(050c) In general, each democratic party should have the chance to assume government responsibilities.	No	No
(050g) Everybody should have the right to defend his own view even if the majority thinks otherwise.	No	No
(1090) Some people prefer lower taxes, although this results in less social services. Others prefer more social services, although this results in raising taxes.	Yes	No
(1130) Should it be easier or more difficult for foreigners to immigrate?	Yes	Yes
(1250) Should the European unification be pushed further in order to establish a joint government soon or has the European unification already gone too far?	No	No
(1290) Some say that the fight against climate change should definitely take precedence, even if it impairs economic growth. Others say that the economic growth should definitely take precedence, even if it impairs the fight against climate change.	Yes	Yes

Policy Item	S.T.	CON.
(1411) Some people think that the state should interfere without restrictions in the privacy and freedom of movement of citizens in order to combat terrorism. Others think that the privacy and freedom of movement of citizens should always be protected even if it hampers the fight against terrorism.	Yes	Yes
(1483a) The use of military force is never justified.	Yes	Yes
(1483b) Germany shouldn't deal with global issues but should focus on its domestic problems.	No	No
(1483c) On foreign policy issues, Germany should act in harmony with the USA.	No	No
(1483d) In international crises, Germany and its allies should agree on a common position.	No	No
(1483e) Germany should play a more active role in global politics.	No	No
(1483g) Germany should take care of its security primarily on its own.	No	No
(2880a) Homosexual civil partnerships should also have the right to adopt children as well.	No	Yes
(2880b) Refugees who come to Germany for economic reasons should be deported.	Yes	Yes
(2880c) Islamic communities should be subject to surveillance by the state.	Yes	Yes
(2880e) Citizens should be able to induce a binding referendum at federal level.	No	No
(2880f) The exercise of the Islamic faith should be restricted in Germany.	Yes	Yes
(2880g) The state should stay out of the economy.	Yes	No
(2880h) State powers in the fight against crime should be extended, even though this will lead to increased surveillance of citizens.	Yes	Yes
(2880j) Rich citizens should pay more taxes in the future than they do now.	Yes	No
(2880k) The federal government should seek to maintain a good relationship with Donald Trump.	No	No
(2880l) Germany should provide financial support for EU member states experiencing great economic and financial difficulties.	Yes	No
(2880m) The federal government should seek to maintain a good relationship with Vladimir Putin.	No	No
(2880t) The state should save companies with many jobs from insolvency.	Yes	No
(2880u) The power supply should be secured even by the use of nuclear power.	Yes	Yes
(2880w) From 2030 onwards, no new cars with petrol or diesel engines should be registered in Germany.	Yes	Yes
(2880x) Germany needs an annual upper limit ('Obergrenze') for refugees.	Yes	Yes
(2880y) Germany's defence expenditure should be increased over the next few years.	Yes	Yes
(2880z) Germany should accept the annexation of Crimea by Russia for the time being.	No	No

Policy Item	S.T.	CON.
(2880aa) The European Union should reduce funding for member states that refuse to take in refugees.	Yes	Yes
(2880ad) A road toll for foreign car drivers should be implemented.	No	No
(2880ae) EU accession negotiations with Turkey should be broken off.	No	No
(2880af) All EU member states should adopt the euro as a common currency.	No	No
(2880ag) The global integration of markets should be pushed forward further.	No	No
(2880ah) Germany should restrict the import of goods from other countries.	No	No
(2880ai) Foreign companies should be allowed to invest in Germany.	No	No
(2880ak) A tax should be introduced on the emission of carbon dioxide (CO ₂).	Yes	Yes
(2880al) The European Union should do more to protect its external borders.	Yes	Yes
(2880ao) The European Union should do more to harmonise living conditions between EU countries.	Yes	No
(2880ap) In order to limit the power of corporations, expropriations should also be carried out.	Yes	No
(2880ba) The state should take on more debt.	No	No
(2880bb) In emergency situations, it is justified for the state to restrict civil liberties.	Yes	Yes
(2880bc) Health protection must take priority over promoting economic growth.	Yes	No
(2880bg) Same-sex partnerships should not be allowed to adopt children.	No	Yes
(2880bh) The use of gender-neutral language (e.g. Burger*innen) should be encouraged by the state.	No	Yes
(2880bi) On all motorways, a speed limit of 130 km/h should apply.	No	No
(2880bt) The state should take more decisive action against political extremists.	No	No

Netherlands

Parentheses contain questions' unique identifiers. Note that some questions have multiple identifiers, as their identifier changed across waves. Answer choices for Likert items sit beside their unscaled numerical values (i.e., the values these choices corresponded to before I rescaled variables to range between 0 and 1.)

Age (gebjaar). Please enter the name, gender [sic] and birth date of every member of your household, including yourself. Also enter this information for members not participating in the panel. Further on in this questionnaire you can indicate which of these persons are participating and which are not. [TEXT BOX] *(To approximate age, the survey-wave year was subtracted from the panelist's birth year.)*

Education (oplnmet). In the table below, please indicate the educational level of the members of your household... [S]elect the highest level that this person has already completed (with a diploma or certificate).

1 = Has not (yet) started any education *(This choice stopped being offered in December 2008.)*

1 = Has not (yet) completed any education

2 = Primary school

3 = VMBO, LBO, MULO, ULO and MAVO (various forms of lower/intermediate secondary education; US: junior high school)

4 = HAVO and VWO, HBS (higher and pre-university secondary education; US: senior high school)

5 = MBO (intermediate professional education)

6 = HBO (higher professional education)

7 = University

NA = Other

Party Identification (233, 235, 309, 310). Which political party are you an adherent of?

- VVD (liberal party)
- PvdA (labor party)

- PVV (Wilders freedom party)
- SP (socialist party)
- CDA (Christian democrat party)
- D66 (social-liberal party)
- ChristenUnie (Christian union party)
- GroenLinks (green party)
- SGP (Christian Reformed party)
- Partij voor de Dieren (animal welfare party)
- 50Plus (fifty plus party)
- Other party, specify... [TEXT BOX]

Political Interest ($\alpha = .80$). *Political interest was measured by averaging panelists' responses to four questions (after rescaling).*

- (8) Are you very interested in the news, fairly interested or not interested? 1 = Not interested; 2 = Fairly interested; 3 = Very interested; NA = I don't know
- (9) If the newspaper reports national news, for example about government issues, do you read that? 1 = Seldom or never; 2 = Occasionally; 3 = Often; 4 = Almost always
- (10) If the newspaper reports international news, for example about tensions or talks between different countries, how often do you read that? 1 = Seldom or never; 2 = Once in a while; 3 = Often; 4 = Almost always
- (11) Are you very interested in political topics, fairly interested or not interested? 1 = Not interested; 2 = Fairly interested; 3 = Very interested

The value questions were introduced with the following text: "Below is a short description of some people. Please indicate for each description whether that person is very much like you, like you, somewhat like you, not like you, or not at all like you?" All value questions were answered with a scale from Not at all like me (1) to Very much like me (6).

Self-Transcendence Values ($\alpha = .70$)

- (hz12a079) It is important to this person to do something for the good of society.

- (hz12a080) It is important for this person to help the people nearby; to care for their well-being.
- (hz12a084) Looking after the environment is important to this person; to care for nature and save life resources.

Conservation Values ($\alpha = .59$)

- (hz12a077) Living in secure surroundings is important to this person; to avoid anything that might be dangerous.
- (hz12a083) It is important to this person to always behave properly; to avoid doing anything people would say is wrong.
- (hz12a085) Tradition is important to this person; to follow the customs handed down by one's religion or family.

Table C2 depicts the policy items and whether my literature review tied that policy item to self-transcendence (S.T.) or conservation (CON.) values. Answer choices are omitted for brevity. These can be found at <https://www.dataarchive.lissdata.nl/>.

Table C2: Policy Items from Longitudinal Internet Studies for the Social Sciences (LISS)

Policy Item	S.T.	CON.
(q102) Some people believe that euthanasia should always be forbidden. Others feel that euthanasia should be permitted if the patient expresses that wish.	No	Yes
(q105) Some people and political parties feel that European unification should go a step further. Others think that European unification has already gone too far.	No	No
(q116) It is good if society consists of people from different cultures.	Yes	Yes
(q118) It should be made easier to obtain asylum in the Netherlands.	Yes	Yes
(q119) Legally residing foreigners should be entitled to the same social security as Dutch citizens.	Yes	Yes
(q120) There are too many people of foreign origin or descent in the Netherlands.	Yes	Yes
(q123) It does not help a neighborhood if many people of foreign origin or descent move in.	Yes	Yes
(q125) People that want to have children should get married.	No	Yes

Policy Item	S.T.	CON.
(q127) It is perfectly fine for a couple to live together without marriage intentions.	No	Yes
(q129) A divorce is generally the best solution if a married couple cannot solve their marital problems.	No	Yes
(q130) It is all right for a married couple with children to get divorced.	No	Yes
(q143) Do you think that women should be able to have a full-time job, a part-time job, or no job at all If she has a baby (a child younger than 1 year)?	No	Yes
(q144) Do you think that women should be able to have a full-time job, a part-time job, or no job at all if she has a child that does not yet attend school?	No	Yes
(q145) Do you think that women should be able to have a full-time job, a part-time job, or no job at all after the youngest child starts primary school?	No	Yes
(q146) Do you think that women should be able to have a full-time job, a part-time job, or no job at all after the youngest child starts secondary school?	No	Yes
(q147) Trade unions should take a much tougher political stance, if they wish to promote the workers' interests.	No	No
(q148) Trade unions should advise their members to vote for those parties that best promote the workers' interests.	No	No

United States

Parentheses contain questions' unique identifiers. Answer choices for Likert items sit beside their unscaled numerical values (i.e., the values these choices corresponded to before I rescaled variables to range between 0 and 1.)

Age (age). How old are you? [TEXT BOX]

Education (degree). Did you ever get a high school diploma or a GED certificate? Do you have any college degrees? What is the highest degree that you have earned?

0. Less than high school
1. High school
2. Associate/junior college
3. Bachelor's
4. Graduate

Party Identification (partyid). Generally speaking, do you usually think of yourself as a Republican, Democrat, Independent, or what?

0. Strong Democrat
1. Not very strong Democrat
2. Independent, close to Democrat
3. Independent
4. Independent, close to Republican
5. Not very strong Republican
6. Strong Republican
7. Other party, refused to say

Political Interest (news). How often do you read the newspaper?

1. Every day
2. A few times a week
3. Once a week
4. Less than once a week

5. Never

The value questions were introduced with the following text: “I will briefly describe some people. Please listen to each description and tell me how much each person is or is not like you. Use this card.” Items were reverse-coded so that higher values indicate greater similarity to the described person. All value questions had response options from Very much like me (1) to Not like me at all (6).

Self-Transcendence Values ($\alpha = .65$)

- (VALEQL) He/she thinks it’s important that every person in the world should be treated equally. He/she believes everyone should have equal opportunities in life.
- (VALLIST) He/she is interested in how people think and why they act the way they do. Even if someone disagrees with him/her, he/she still wants to understand them.
- (VALCARE) It’s very important to him/her to help the people around him/her. He/she wants to care for their well-being.
- (VALDVOT) It is important to him/her to be loyal to his/her friends. He/she wants to devote himself/herself to people close to him/her.
- (VALECO) He/she strongly believes that people should care for nature. Looking after the environment is important to him/her.

Conservation Values ($\alpha = .73$)

- (VALSAFE) It is important to him/her to live in secure surroundings. He/she avoids anything that might endanger his/her safety.
- (VALRULE) He/she believes that people should do what they’re told. He/she thinks people should follow rules at all times, even when no-one is watching.
- (VALMOD) It is important to him/her to be humble and modest. He/she tries not to draw attention to himself/herself.
- (VALDFND) It is important to him/her that his/her country is strong so it can defend its citizens.
- (VALPRPR) It is important to him/her always to behave properly. He/she wants to avoid doing anything people would say is wrong.

- (VALTRDN) Tradition is important to him/her. He/she tries to follow the customs handed down by his/her religion or his/her family.

Table C3 depicts the policy items and whether my literature review tied that policy item to self-transcendence (S.T.) or conservation (CON.) values. Answer choices are omitted for brevity. These can be found at <https://gss.norc.umd.edu/content/dam/gss/get-documentation/pdf/codebook/Panel%20Codebook.pdf>.

Table C3: Policy Items from General Social Survey (GSS) Panel

Policy Item	S.T.	CON.
(natenvir) Are we spending too much, too little, or about the right amount on: Improving and protecting the environment?	Yes	Yes
(natheal) Are we spending too much, too little, or about the right amount on: Improving and protecting the nation's health?	Yes	No
(natcrime) Are we spending too much, too little, or about the right amount on: Halting the rising crime rate?	Yes	Yes
(nateduc) Are we spending too much, too little, or about the right amount on: Improving the nation's education system?	No	No
(natrace) Are we spending too much, too little, or about the right amount on: Improving the conditions of Blacks?	Yes	Yes
(natarms) Are we spending too much, too little, or about the right amount on: The military, armaments and defense?	Yes	Yes
(nataid) Are we spending too much, too little, or about the right amount on: Foreign aid?	No	No
(natfare) Are we spending too much, too little, or about the right amount on: Welfare?	Yes	No
(nat soc) Are we spending too much, too little, or about the right amount on: Social Security?	Yes	No
(natchld) Are we spending too much, too little, or about the right amount on: Assistance for childcare?	Yes	No
(natenviy) Are we spending too much, too little, or about the right amount on: The environment?	Yes	Yes
(nathealy) Are we spending too much, too little, or about the right amount on: Health?	Yes	No
(natcrimy) Are we spending too much, too little, or about the right amount on: Law enforcement?	Yes	Yes
(nateducy) Are we spending too much, too little, or about the right amount on: Education?	No	No

Policy Item	S.T.	CON.
(natracey) Are we spending too much, too little, or about the right amount on: Assistance to blacks?	Yes	Yes
(natarmsy) Are we spending too much, too little, or about the right amount on: National defense?	Yes	Yes
(nataidy) Are we spending too much, too little, or about the right amount on: Assistance to other countries?	No	No
(natfarey) Are we spending too much, too little, or about the right amount on: Assistance to the poor?	Yes	Yes
(cappun) Do you favor or oppose the death penalty for persons convicted of murder?	Yes	Yes
(gunlaw) Would you favor or oppose a law which would require a person to obtain a police permit before he or she could buy a gun?	No	No
(courts) In general, do you think the courts in this area deal too harshly or not harshly enough with criminals?	Yes	Yes
(grass) Do you think the use of marijuana should be made legal or not?	No	Yes
(racopen) Suppose there is a community-wide vote on the general housing issue. There are two possible laws to vote on. Which law would you vote for? One law says that a homeowner can decide for himself whom to sell his house to, even if he prefers not to sell to (Negroes / Blacks / African-Americans). The second law says that a homeowner cannot refuse to sell to someone because of their race or color.	Yes	Yes
(affrmact) Some people say that because of past discrimination, blacks should be given preference in hiring and promotion. Are you for or against preferential hiring and promotion of blacks?	Yes	Yes
(letin1a) Do you think the number of immigrants to America nowadays should be increased a lot, increased a little, remain the same as it is, decreased a little, or decreased a lot?	Yes	Yes
(abdefect) Should it be possible for a pregnant woman to obtain a legal abortion if there is a strong chance of serious defect in the baby?	No	Yes
(abnomore) Should it be possible for a pregnant woman to obtain a legal abortion if she is married and does not want any more children?	No	Yes
(abhlth) Should it be possible for a pregnant woman to obtain a legal abortion if the woman's own health is seriously endangered by the pregnancy?	No	Yes
(abpoor) Should it be possible for a pregnant woman to obtain a legal abortion if the family has a very low income and cannot afford any more children?	No	Yes
(abrape) Should it be possible for a pregnant woman to obtain a legal abortion if she became pregnant as a result of rape?	No	Yes
(absingle) Should it be possible for a pregnant woman to obtain a legal abortion if she is not married and does not want to marry the man?	No	Yes
(abany) Should it be possible for a pregnant woman to obtain a legal abortion if the woman wants it for any reason?	No	Yes

Policy Item	S.T.	CON.
(pillok) Do you strongly agree, agree, disagree, or strongly disagree that methods of birth control should be available to teenagers between the ages of 14 and 16?	No	Yes
(sexeduc) Would you be for or against sex education in the public schools?	No	Yes
(divlaw) Should divorce in this country be easier or more difficult to obtain than it is now?	No	Yes
(marhomo) Do you agree or disagree: Homosexual couples should have the right to marry one another?	No	Yes
(suicide1) Do you think a person has the right to end his or her own life if this person has an incurable disease?	No	Yes
(suicide2) Do you think a person has the right to end his or her own life if this person has gone bankrupt?	No	Yes
(suicide3) Do you think a person has the right to end his or her own life if this person has dishonored his or her family?	No	Yes
(suicide4) Do you think a person has the right to end his or her own life if this person is tired of living and ready to die?	No	Yes
(polabuse) Would you approve of a policeman striking a citizen who had said vulgar and obscene things to the policeman?	Yes	Yes
(polmurdr) Would you approve of a policeman striking a citizen who was being questioned as a suspect in a murder case?	Yes	Yes
(polescap) Would you approve of a policeman striking a citizen who was attempting to escape from custody?	Yes	Yes
(polattak) Would you approve of a policeman striking a citizen who was attacking the policeman with his fists?	Yes	Yes
(helppoor) Some people think the government in Washington should do everything possible to improve the standard of living of all poor Americans. Others think it is not the government's responsibility and that each person should take care of himself.	Yes	No
(helpsick) Some people think it is the responsibility of the government in Washington to see to it that people have help in paying for doctors and hospital bills. Others think that these matters are not the responsibility of the federal government.	Yes	No
(helpblk) Some people think that Blacks have been discriminated against for so long that the government has a special obligation to help improve their living standards. Others believe that the government should not be giving special treatment to Blacks.	Yes	Yes
(fehired) Because of past discrimination, employers should make special efforts to hire and promote qualified women. Do you strongly agree, agree, neither agree nor disagree, disagree, or strongly disagree?	No	No
(fejobaff) Some people say that because of past discrimination, women should be given preference in hiring and promotion. Others say that such preference is wrong because it discriminates against men.	No	No

Policy Item	S.T.	CON.
(taxshare) Do you think that people with high incomes should pay a larger share of their income in taxes than those with low incomes, the same share, or a smaller share?	Yes	No
(taxrich) Generally, how would you describe taxes in America today for those with high incomes are taxes too high, about right, or too low?	Yes	No
(letdie1) When a person has a disease that cannot be cured, do you think doctors should be allowed by law to end the patient's life by some painless means if the patient and his family request it?	No	Yes
(natcity) Are we spending too much, too little, or about the right amount on: Solving the problems of the big cities?	No	No
(natdrug) Are we spending too much, too little, or about the right amount on: Dealing with drug addiction?	No	No
(natmass) Are we spending too much, too little, or about the right amount on: Mass transportation?	No	No
(natpark) Are we spending too much, too little, or about the right amount on: Parks and recreation?	No	No
(natsci) Are we spending too much, too little, or about the right amount on: Supporting scientific research?	No	No
(natspac) Are we spending too much, too little, or about the right amount on: Space exploration program?	No	No
(spkath) If somebody who is against all churches and religion wanted to make a speech in your community against churches and religion, should he be allowed to speak, or not?	No	No
(spkcom) Suppose an admitted Communist wanted to make a speech in your community. Should he be allowed to speak, or not?	No	No
(spkhomo) If a man who admits to being homosexual wanted to make a speech in your community, should he be allowed to speak, or not?	No	No
(spkmil) Consider a person who advocates doing away with elections and letting the military run the country. Should such a person be allowed to make a speech in your community?	No	No
(spkmslm) Consider a Muslim clergyman who preaches hatred of the United States. Should such a person be allowed to make a speech in your community?	No	No
(spkrac) Consider a person who believes that Blacks are genetically inferior. Should such a person be allowed to make a speech in your community?	No	No
(advfront) Even if it brings no immediate benefits, scientific research that advances the frontiers of knowledge is necessary and should be supported by the federal government. Do you strongly agree, agree, disagree, or strongly disagree?	No	No
(colath) Should a person who is against all churches and religion be allowed to teach in a college or university?	No	No
(colcom) Suppose an admitted Communist is teaching in a college. Should he be fired, or not?	No	No

Policy Item	S.T.	CON.
(colhomo) Should a man who admits to being homosexual be allowed to teach in a college or university?	No	No
(colmil) Should a person who advocates doing away with elections and letting the military run the country be allowed to teach in a college or university?	No	No
(colmslm) Should a Muslim clergyman who preaches hatred of the United States be allowed to teach in a college or university?	No	No
(colrac) Should a person who believes that Blacks are genetically inferior be allowed to teach in a college or university?	No	No
(libath) If a person who is against all churches and religion wrote a book against churches and religion, should that book be taken out of your public library?	No	No
(libcom) If an admitted Communist wrote a book, should that book be removed from your public library?	No	No
(libhomo) If a man who admits to being homosexual wrote a book in favor of homosexuality, should that book be taken out of your public library?	No	No
(libmil) If a person who advocates doing away with elections and letting the military run the country wrote a book, should that book be removed from your public library?	No	No
(libmslm) If a Muslim clergyman who preaches hatred of the United States wrote a book, should that book be taken out of your public library?	No	No
(librac) If a person who believes that Blacks are genetically inferior wrote a book saying Blacks are inferior, should that book be taken out of your public library?	No	No

Appendix D: Identifying Value-Policy Pairs for Analysis

Before conducting the main analyses, I needed to identify which policy items in the panel datasets should relate to conservation and self-transcendence values. I did so through a systematic literature review.

On February 10, 2026, I searched Scopus for English-language journal articles published since 2010. Articles had to mention the following in their title, abstract, or keywords: *values*; some variation of *politics* or *policy*; and some variation of *attitude*, *belief*, *opinion*, or *preference*.¹⁰ Additionally, the full text of the article had to name at least one Schwartz value of interest¹¹ and cite an author named Schwartz.

I then reviewed the abstract of each article—and the full article text in ambiguous cases—to identify those that quantitatively estimated the relationship between basic values and policy opinions within a broad sample. This yielded 24 articles. I supplemented these with 18 other articles that I already knew of or that were returned by a similar search of Google Scholar.

Next, I reviewed all 42 publications in full, recording the direction and significance of reported associations between values and policy opinions, along with descriptions of the policy types underlying each association. Importantly, some studies reported effects for higher-order values (e.g., conservation) and the lower-order values that constitute them (e.g., tradition, security). In these cases, I referred to the associations between higher-order values and policy opinions. Other studies only examined associations between lower-order values and policy opinions. In such cases, I inferred the effect for the higher-order value from its lower-order values, provided their effects did not significantly conflict. For example, if all three lower-order values of conservation (i.e., conformity, tradition, and security) were positively associated with a policy opinion—or if some were positive and others null—I considered conservation to have a positive association with that opinion. If there were significant, oppositely signed associations between the lower-order values and the opinion, I recorded the relationship as “mixed.”

¹⁰The exact query was *(politic* OR polic*) AND (attitud* OR belief* OR opinion* OR preference*)*.

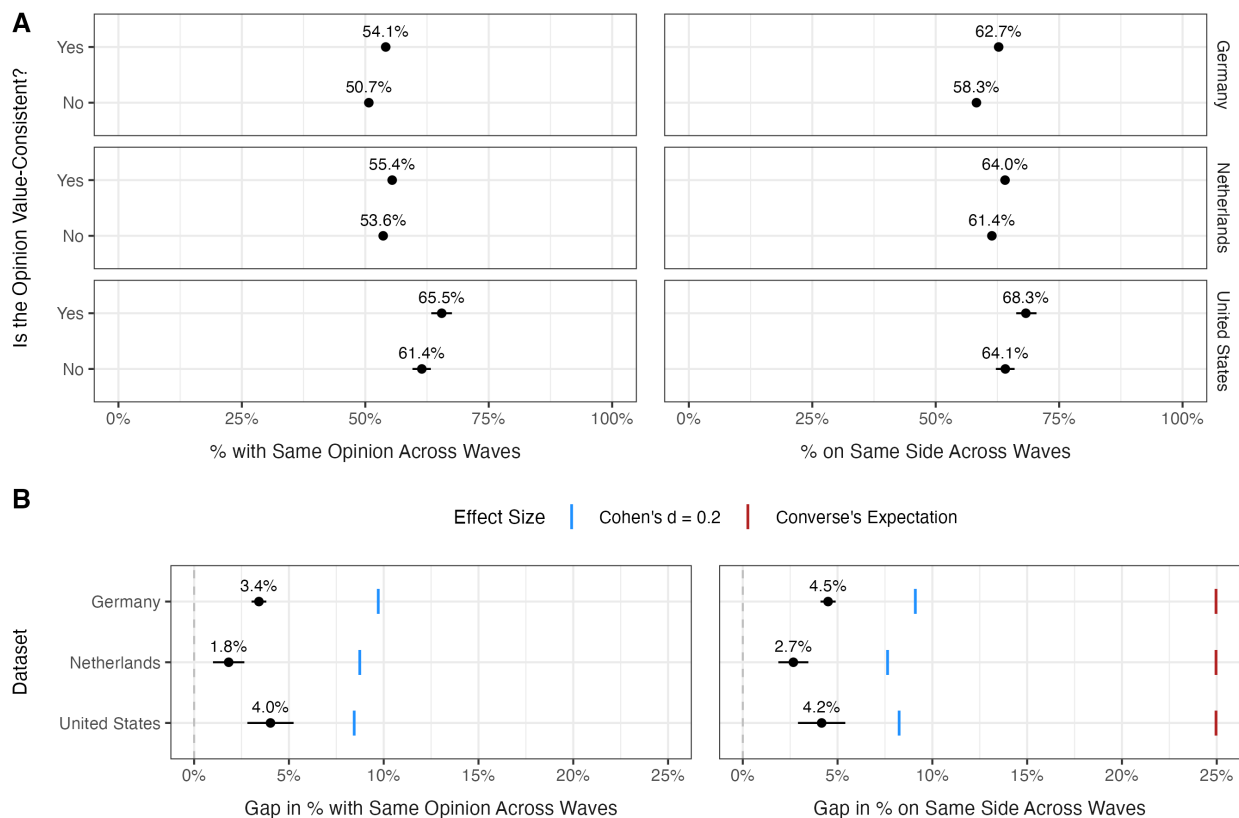
¹¹The exact query was *(self-transcendence OR conservation OR universalism OR benevolence OR conformity OR tradition OR security)*.

Finally, I identified which associations were consistent across studies and sub-groups of respondents. An association was consistent if, when statistically significant, it always pointed in the same direction. Null effects in some studies were acceptable, as they may reflect limited statistical power. But if, say, conservation values were positively associated with economic conservatism in one study or sub-group but negatively associated in another, the association was not considered consistent. The results of this process are presented in the print appendix.

Appendix E: Results When Including Shorter Scales

The main analyses use only five- to seven-point Likert items for comparability. Here, I extend the analysis to all relevant policy items, including binary ones. As shown in Figure E1, results closely mirror those in the main paper.

Figure E1: Results When Using All Policy Items



Note: Sub-figure A shows the predicted stability of value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions. Sub-figure B visualizes the gap between these estimates alongside two benchmarks: Cohen's $d = 0.2$ and Converse's expected gap between citizens and legislators. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist. Data weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight.

Appendix F: Results When Empirically Defining Value-Policy Alignment

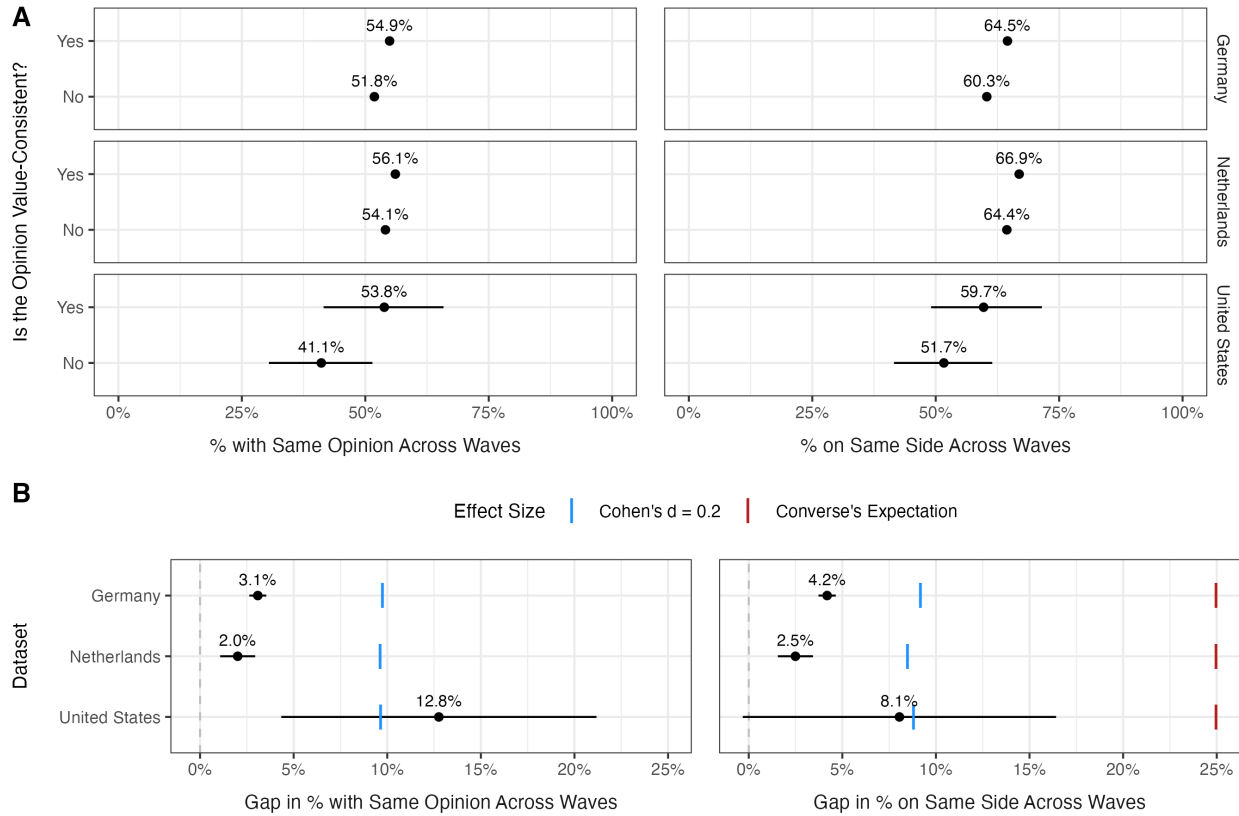
The main analyses rely on a literature-derived mapping of values to policy opinions, which may involve contestable judgment calls. As an alternative, I replicated the analyses using a purely empirical approach. For each policy opinion, I estimated the following regression:

$$Opinion_{i,t} = \beta_1 * SelfTranscendence_i + \beta_2 * Conservation_i + \beta_3 * Acquiescence + \delta_t + \epsilon$$

Here, *Opinion* is panelist *i*'s position on the issue at wave *t*, *SelfTranscendence* and *Conservation* capture endorsement of each value dimension, *Acquiescence* controls for indiscriminate agreement with value statements, and represents wave fixed effects. The table below reports the estimated coefficients. I adjusted for multiple comparisons using the Holm (1979) method ($p < .05$). If a value had a significant effect on a policy opinion, after adjusting for multiple comparisons, the direction of that effect dictated the “proper” direction of the association.

Figure F1 presents these results, which broadly match the main findings. The U.S. estimates grow noisier under this specification but remain consistent with a small effect.

Figure F1: Results When Empirically Defining Value-Policy Alignment



Note: Sub-figure A shows the predicted stability of value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions. Sub-figure B visualizes the gap between these estimates alongside two benchmarks: Cohen's $d = 0.2$ and Converse's expected gap between citizens and legislators. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist. Data weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight.

Appendix G: Modeling Case-Wise Heterogeneity

To assess whether the association between value-consistency and stability varies by value or policy issue, I estimate a separate OLS regression for each value-policy pairing:

$$OpinionStable_{i,t} = \beta_1 * ValueConsistent_{i,t} + \beta * Traits_{i,t} + \delta_{s,t} + \epsilon$$

Here, *OpinionStable* equals one if panelist *i*'s opinion remained on the same side of the issue over period *t*, and *ValueConsistent* equals one if the opinion aligned with the relevant value at the period's start. *Traits* includes education, political interest, age, and—following convention in values research—acquiescence (Schwartz 1992). “Trend” fixed effects (δ) absorb variation due to the initial stance held on a policy issue (e.g., left, center, or right). Figure 3 in the main paper visualizes the results of these models.

Appendix H: Does Time Affect the Stability Gap?

Longer gaps between waves might erode opinion stability or widen the gap between value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions. To test this, I estimated the following OLS regression for each panel:

$$\begin{aligned} OpinionStable_{i,p,t} = & \beta_1 * ValueConsistent_{i,p,v,t} + \beta_2 * YearsElapsed_{i,p,t} + \\ & \beta_3 * ValueConsistent_{i,p,v,t} * YearsElapsed_{i,p,t} + \alpha_{p,v} + \delta_{s,p} + \epsilon \end{aligned}$$

The dependent variable, *OpinionStable*, equals one if panelist i held the same position on policy issue p across period t . *ValueConsistent* flags whether that opinion aligned with value v at the period’s start, and *YearsElapsed* measures the period’s duration in years.

Two sets of fixed effects address unobserved heterogeneity. “Case” fixed effects (α) restrict comparisons to within a given value-policy pairing. “Trend” fixed effects (δ) absorb differences tied to the initial stance on an issue (e.g., left, center, or right), since some positions—such as moderate ones—may be inherently less stable.

As shown in the table below, longer inter-wave gaps slightly reduce average opinion stability, but they do not widen the consistency-stability gap.

Table H1: Does Period Length Affect the Stability Gap?

	Germany		Netherlands		United States	
	Same Opinion	Same Side	Same Opinion	Same Side	Same Opinion	Same Side
Value-Consistent	0.033 (0.002)	0.039 (0.002)	0.022 (0.005)	0.027 (0.005)	0.042 (0.018)	0.058 (0.018)
Years Between Waves	-0.017 (0.090)	-0.017 (0.092)	-0.008 (0.061)	-0.006 (0.056)	-0.022 (0.066)	-0.014 (0.059)
Interaction	0.000 (0.182)	0.003 (0.184)	0.001 (0.101)	0.002 (0.093)	0.005 (0.126)	-0.001 (0.131)
Num.Obs.	10231703	10231703	662936	662936	11160	11160
RMSE	0.49	0.45	0.48	0.41	0.49	0.46

Note: This model includes case and policy-stance fixed effects. Data weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight. Wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist in parentheses.

Appendix I: Stability of Political Values vs. Policy Opinions

Scholars question whether political values are distinct from, or exogenous to, policy opinions (Arceneaux et al. 2024). Rather than shaping policy opinions, these values may simply summarize citizens' views within a particular domain.

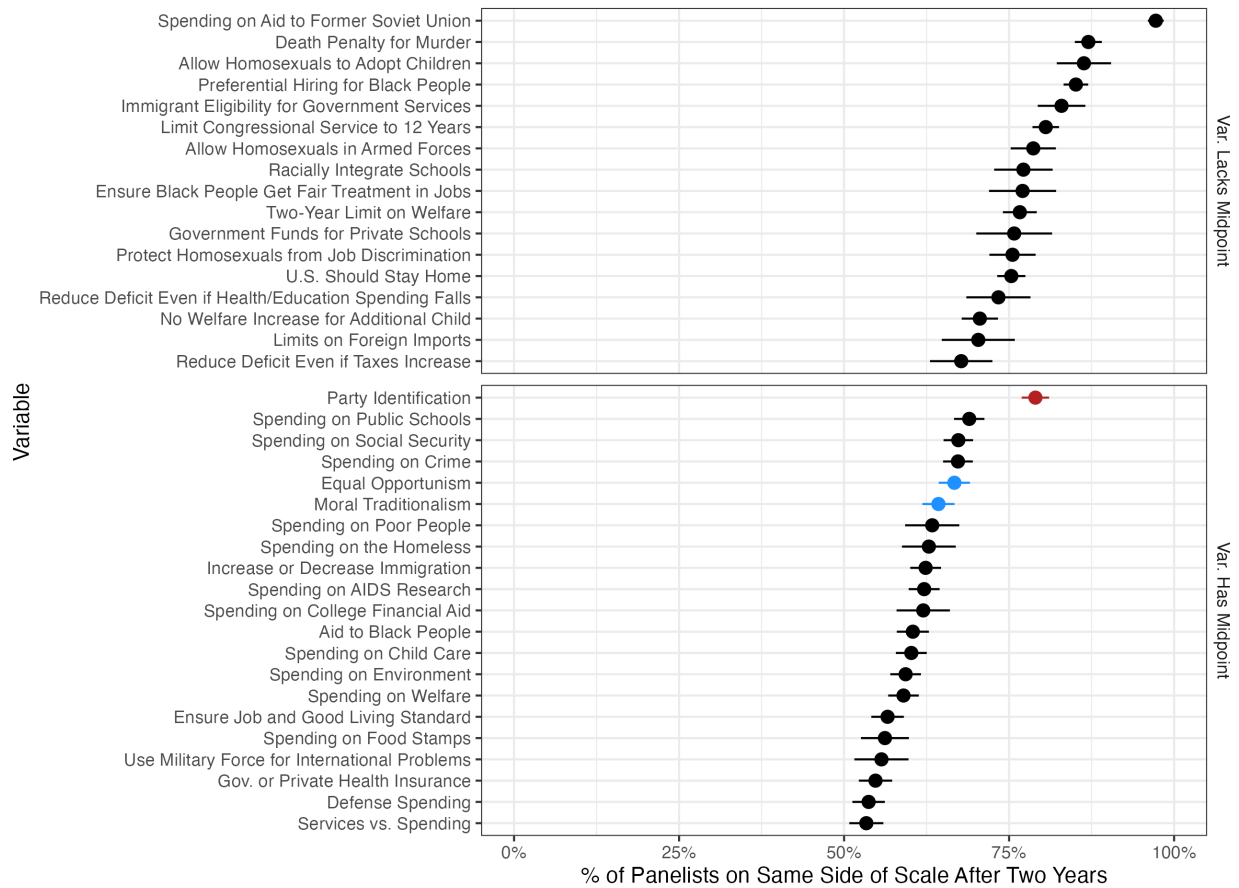
To investigate, I drew on the 1992–96 and 2016–24 panels from the American National Election Study (Sapiro et al. 1999, American National Election Studies (2025)). All variables were trisected (left-wing, scale midpoint, right-wing) to ensure comparability, and the data were restructured so each row represents panelist i 's score on variable v at the beginning and end of period t . I then estimated this OLS regression for each dataset:

$$Stable_{i,v,t} = \beta_0 + \beta * Variable_v + \delta_t + \epsilon$$

Stable equals one if panelist i stood on the same side of variable v across period t ; *Variable* is a factor identifying the variable; and δ captures period fixed effects.

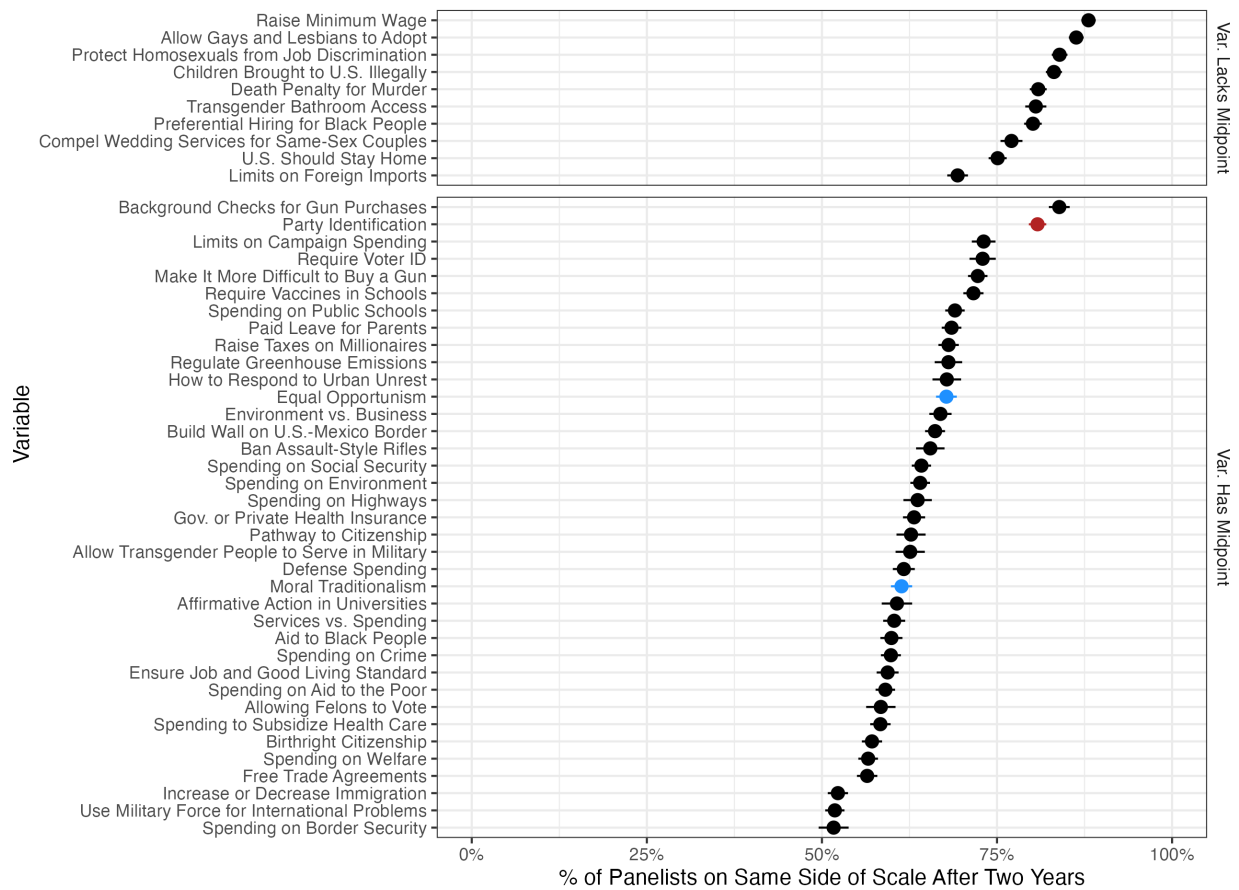
Figure I1 and Figure I2 display the predicted stability of each variable, revealing that political values are roughly as unstable as policy opinions.

Figure I1: Stability of Political Values vs. Policy Opinions (ANES 1992–96 Panel)



Note: Predicted stability of variables in the ANES 1992–96 panel. Blue points represent political value indexes; black points represent policy opinions; and red points represent party identification. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from standard errors clustered by panelist.

Figure I2: Stability of Political Values vs. Policy Opinions (ANES 2016–24 Panel)



Note: Predicted stability of variables in the ANES 2016–24 panel. Blue points represent political value indexes; black points represent policy opinions; and red points represent party identification. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from standard errors clustered by panelist.

Appendix J: Stability of Basic Values vs. Policy Opinions

A separate German panel—the Leibniz Institute for the Social Sciences (GESIS) panel—allows a direct comparison of the stability of basic values and policy opinions (?). It measured 6,165 panelists’ basic values across ten waves and also contains repeated measures of 31 policy opinions.

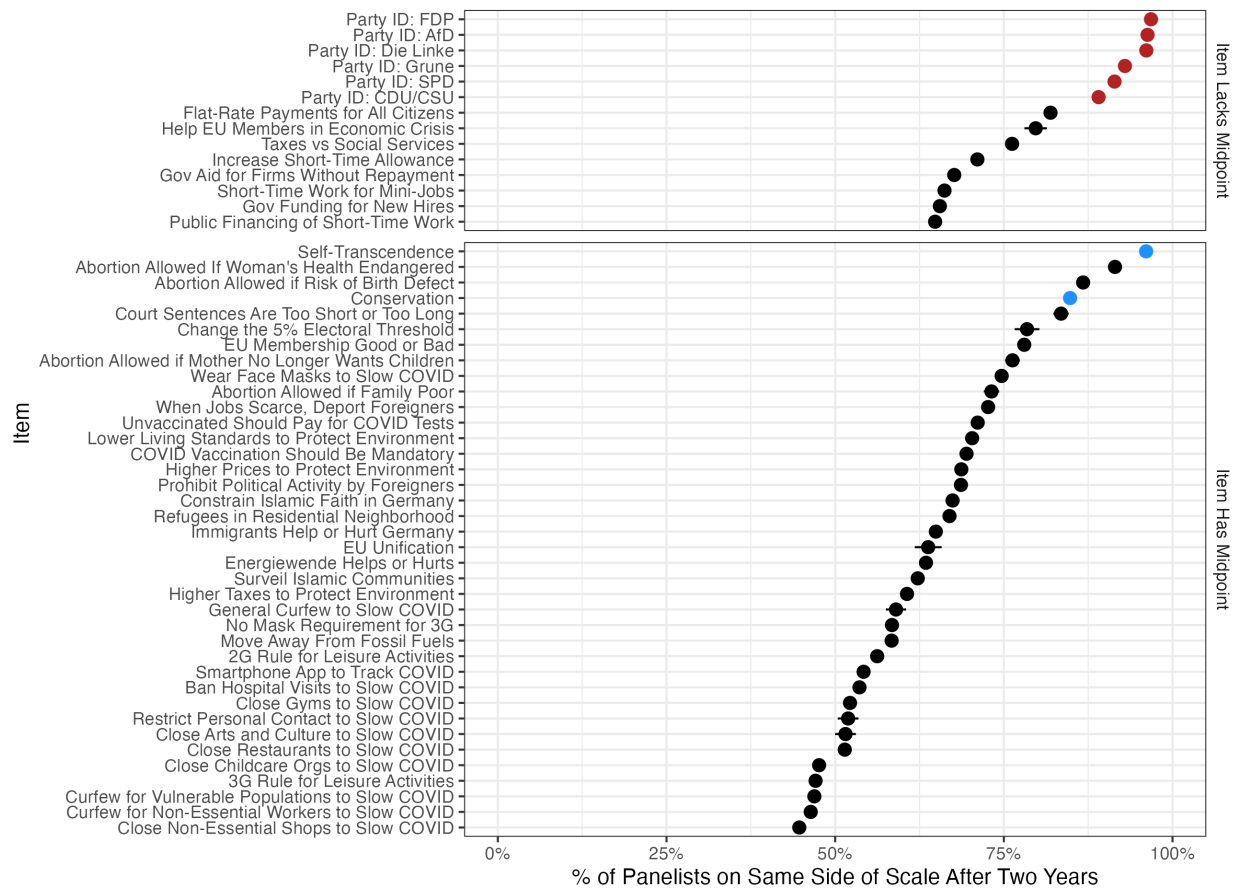
All variables were trisected (left-wing, scale midpoint, right-wing) to ensure comparability, and the data were restructured so each row represents panelist i ’s score on variable v at the beginning and end of period t . I then estimated:

$$Stable_{i,v,t} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 * Years_t + \beta * Variable_v + \epsilon$$

Stable is defined as before; *Years* captures the period length; and *Variable* identifies the variable. I do not use period fixed effects in this model of because of insufficient overlap in variables across waves.

Figure J1 displays the results. In a typical year, 97% and 86% of panelists remained stable on self-transcendence and conservation values, respectively. Most policy opinions were far less stable (*Average Stability* = 66%). Only two policy opinions showed more stability than conservation values.

Figure J1: Stability of Basic Values vs. Policy Opinions



Note: Predicted stability of variables in the GESIS Panel. Blue points represent basic value indexes; black points represent policy opinions; and red points represent party identification. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from standard errors clustered by panelist.

Appendix K: Value-Policy Correlations Over Time

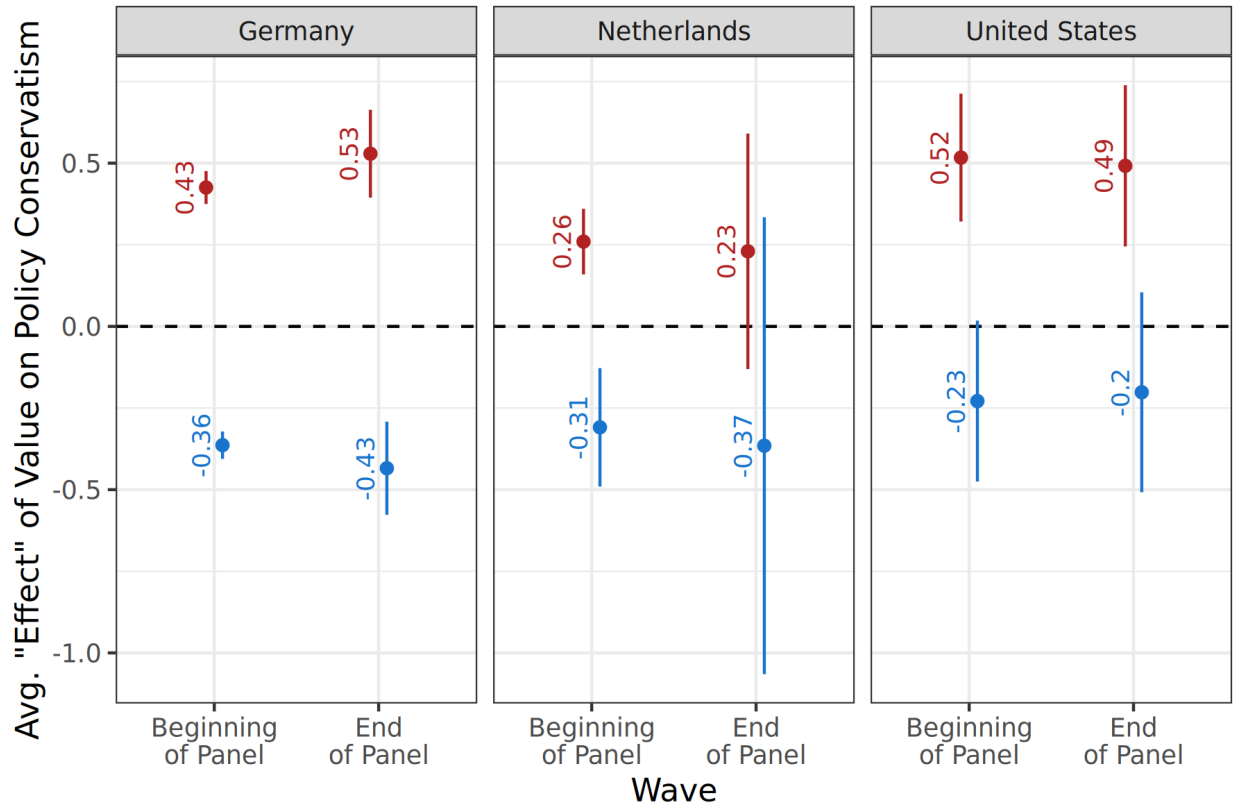
Each panel in the main analysis measures values once—at the start (Germany, Netherlands) or end (United States)—so I cannot directly verify that values remained stable throughout. I can, however, test an implication of value change: If values shifted, their average cross-sectional association with related policy opinions should weaken as the measurement grows stale. Individual value-policy correlations may increase or decrease with changing circumstances, but an average across many opinions should predominantly reflect the passage of time. For each value and panel, I estimated:

$$\begin{aligned} Policy_{i,p,t} = & \beta_1 * Value_i + \beta_2 * Years_{i,p,t} + \beta_3 * Acquiescence_i + \\ & \beta_4 * Value_i * Years_{i,p,t} + \beta_5 Years_{i,p,t} * Acquiescence_i + \beta_6 * Value_i * Acquiescence_i \\ & + \beta_7 * Value_i * Years_{i,p,t} * Acquiescence_i + \gamma_p + \varepsilon_{i,p,t} \end{aligned}$$

Policy is panelist i 's opinion on issue p at wave t ; *Value* captures endorsement of the related value; *Years* is the gap (in years) between the value and policy measurements; *Acquiescence* controls for indiscriminate agreement with value statements; and γ denotes policy-issue fixed effects. I utilize a complete-interaction model to minimize bias in my estimates (Blackwell and Olson 2022).

Figure K1 displays the associational “effect” of panelists’ values on their policy opinions at the beginning and end of each panel. These effects change very little, though each panel spans many years. Indeed, if anything, the effects of values tend to grow with time. Notably, standard errors grow as the time between value and policy measurements increases. However, this is primarily a function of sample attrition: The number of observations decreases in later waves, naturally increasing the standard errors. Crucially, the point estimates remain stable across all waves. If true value change were occurring, we would expect the coefficients to decay toward zero; instead, they remain constant despite the reduced statistical power. Additionally, if value change were the culprit, the standard errors for middle-aged panelists—the group with the most stable values (see Online Appendix L)—should stay relatively flat or grow much slower than the rest of the sample. Their standard errors grow even faster, suggesting that the noise has nothing to do with shifting values.

Figure K1: Associational “Effect” of Values on Policy Conservatism by Time

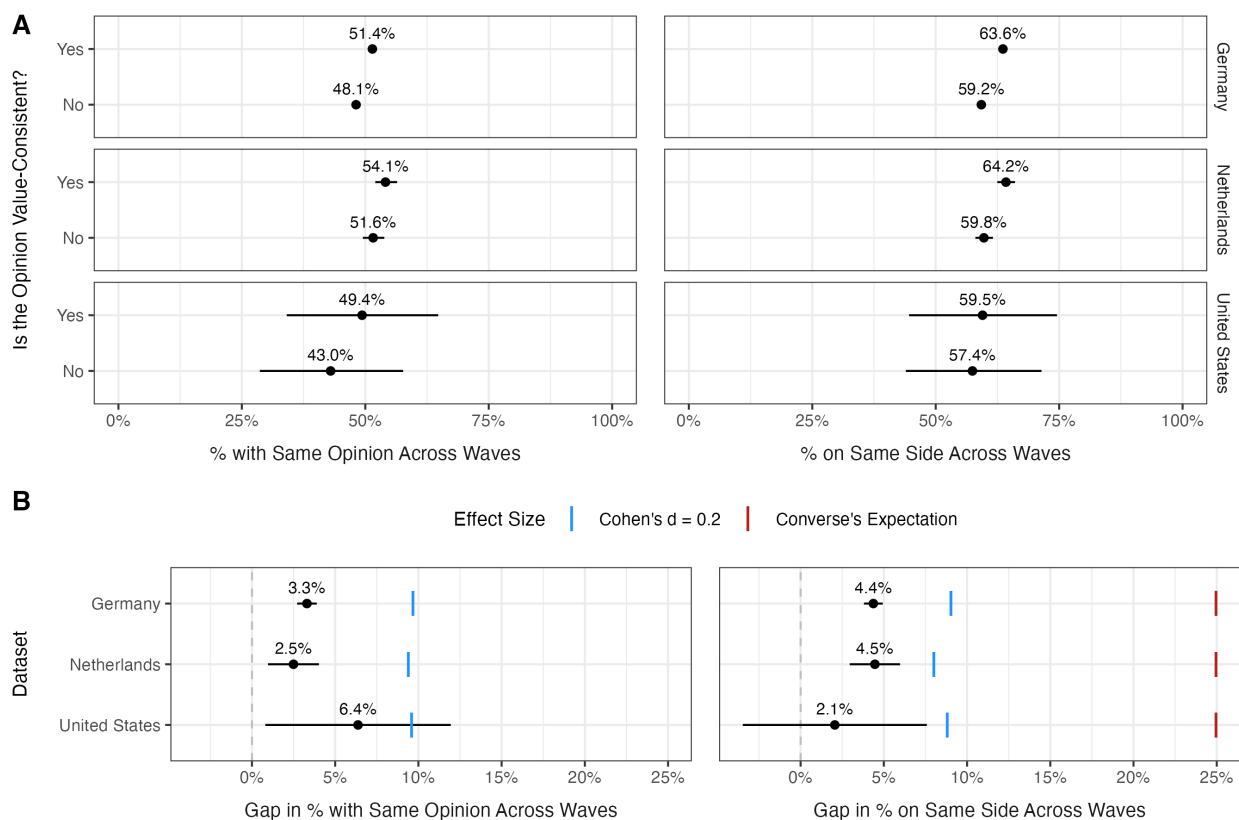


Note: Associational “effect” of panelists’ values on policy conservatism at the beginning and end of each panel. Blue points represent the effects of self-transcendence values; red points represent the effects of conservation values. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist. Data weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight.

Appendix L: Results Among the Middle-Aged

If over-time value change were attenuating the estimates from my main analyses, restricting the sample to panelists with the most stable values should alter the results. Past research identifies 40- to 60-year-olds as the group least likely to shift in their values (Milfont, Milojev and Sibley 2016). Figure L1 confirms that results for this age group track the main findings closely. Point estimates in Figure L1 resemble the full-sample estimates, though the U.S. coefficients become imprecise due to the smaller sample.

Figure L1: Results Among Middle-Aged

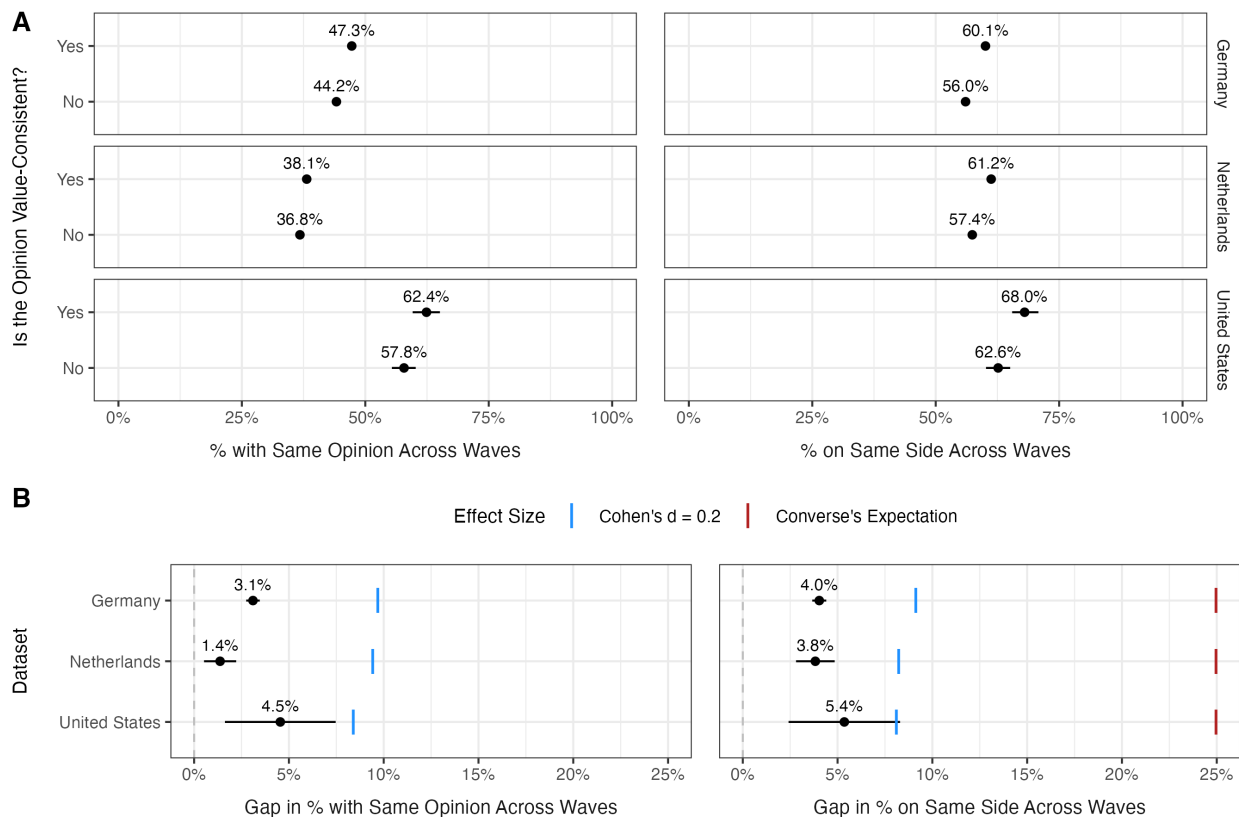


Note: Sub-figure A shows the predicted stability of value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions. Sub-figure B visualizes the gap between these estimates alongside two benchmarks: Cohen's $d = 0.2$ and Converse's expected gap between citizens and legislators. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist. Data weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight.

Appendix M: Results When Using Indexes of Policy Opinions

Measurement error in individual policy items could inflate instability. To guard against this, I replicated the analyses using policy-opinion indexes (Ansolabehere, Rodden and Snyder 2008). Within each panel dataset, I identified pairs of policy opinions that were measured on the same waves, conceptually related, and strongly correlated ($r < -.3$ or $r > .3$). This process yielded 22 indexes. Figure M1 confirms that the results align with the main findings.

Figure M1: Results When Using Indexes of Policy Opinions



Note: Sub-figure A shows the predicted stability of value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions. Sub-figure B visualizes the gap between these estimates alongside two benchmarks: Cohen's $d = 0.2$ and Converse's expected gap between citizens and legislators. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist. Data weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight.

Appendix N: Results When Using Continuous Measures

The main analyses rely on binary indicators of value-consistency and opinion stability. Binarization simplifies interpretation but may introduce measurement error, so I re-estimate the models using continuous alternatives. Value-consistency is measured as one minus the absolute distance between a panelist's value score and policy opinion (flipped so that they correlate positively). Opinion stability is similarly defined as one minus the absolute change in the panelist's opinion across waves.

The table below reports the results. The link between value-consistency and opinion stability remains modest. The United States shows the largest effect: Moving from the bottom to the top of the value-consistency scale cuts the average change in policy opinions by six percentage points. Put differently, a one-standard-deviation increase in value-consistency increases opinion stability by roughly 7% of a standard deviation.

Table N1: Results Using Continuous Measures

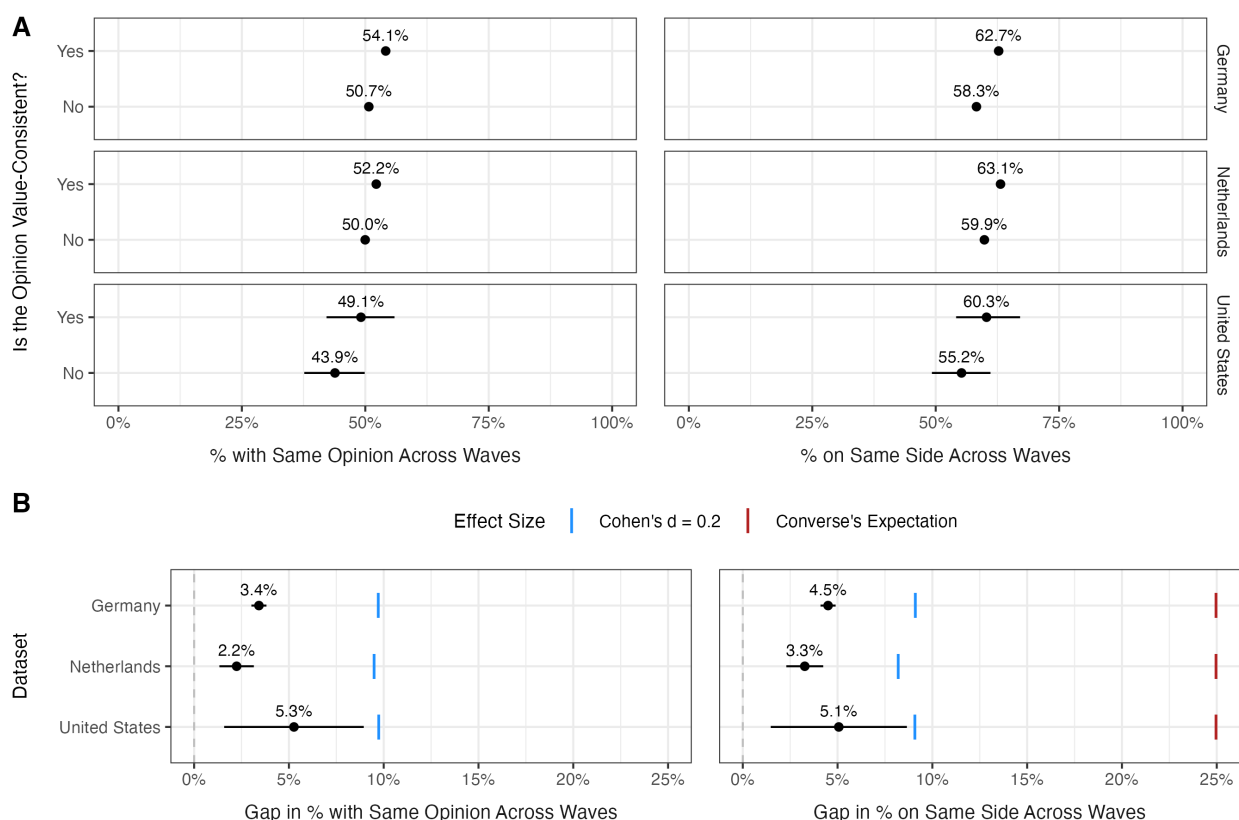
	Germany	Netherlands	United States
Value-Consistency	0.043 (0.002)	0.050 (0.005)	0.062 (0.017)
Education	0.036 (0.002)	0.023 (0.005)	0.059 (0.013)
Political Interest	0.000 (0.002)	0.000 (0.005)	0.013 (0.011)
Age	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)
Acquiescence	-0.037 (0.005)	-0.037 (0.012)	-0.036 (0.040)
Num.Obs.	10 438 870	769 773	11 334
RMSE	0.18	0.16	0.21

Note: This model includes case and trend fixed effects. Data weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight. Wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist in parentheses.

Appendix O: Results When Values Are Important

Conservation and self-transcendence may matter little to some respondents, potentially diluting the consistency-stability link. To address this, I first compute value importance following Schwartz et al. (2001): For each participant, I calculate the absolute distance between their self-transcendence and conservation ratings and their mean agreement across all values. I then re-run the main models restricted to the top third of respondents on this importance measure. Figure O1 shows that limiting the sample in this way does not meaningfully change the results.

Figure O1: Results Among Those Who Care Most About Values



Note: Sub-figure A shows the predicted stability of value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions. Sub-figure B visualizes the gap between these estimates alongside two benchmarks: Cohen's $d = 0.2$ and Converse's expected gap between citizens and legislators. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist. Data weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight.

Appendix P: Results for Strongest Value-Policy Cases

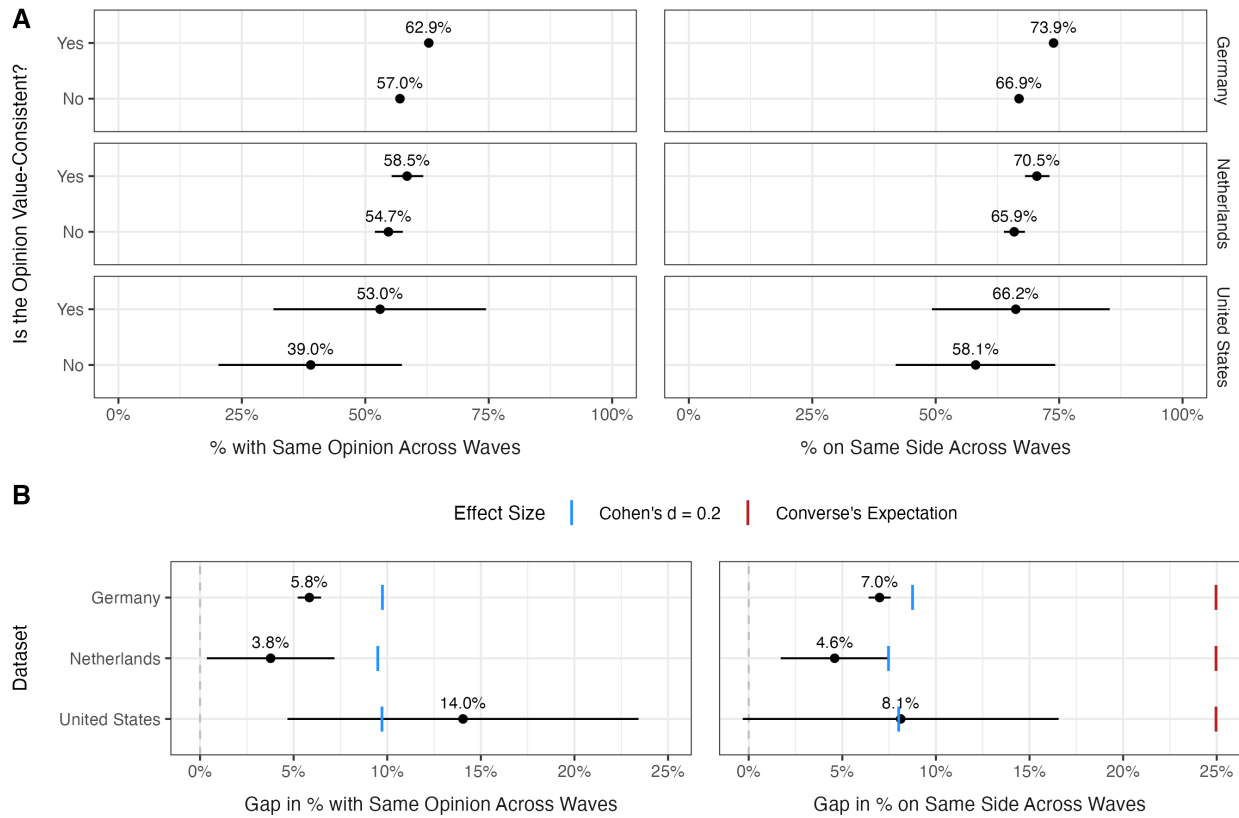
Perhaps the modest consistency-stability link reflects the fact that basic values are too distal from politics. If so, the link should be stronger among value-policy pairs with the tightest cross-sectional association. To identify such pairs, I estimated this OLS regression for each case and dataset:

$$Policy_{i,t} = \beta_1 * Value_i + \beta_2 * Acquiescence_i + \lambda_t + \epsilon_{i,t}$$

Policy is panelist *i*'s position on a policy issue at wave *t*, collapsed to a three-point scale (left-wing, midpoint, right-wing). *Value* captures endorsement of the corresponding value. *Acquiescence* controls for the tendency to agree with all value statements regardless of content (Schwartz 1992). λ denotes wave fixed effects.

From these models, I identified those cases wherein the cross-sectional association between a value and policy opinion was robust (*Standardized* $\beta \geq .3$). Restricting the stability-consistency analysis to these strongly associated pairs yields Figure P1. The pattern is consistent with the main findings, though U.S. estimates again lose precision—without, however, becoming statistically distinguishable from a small effect.

Figure P1: Results for Strongest Value-Policy Cases



Note: Sub-figure A shows the predicted stability of value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions. Sub-figure B visualizes the gap between these estimates alongside two benchmarks: Cohen's $d = 0.2$ and Converse's expected gap between citizens and legislators. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist. Data weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight.

Appendix Q: Results Among Educated and Interested Participants

My value-consistency measure may not distinguish deliberate, value-driven reasoning from coincidental alignment. If much of the observed consistency is incidental, the true link between principled opinion-holding and stability may be understated. This link should be strongest among citizens most capable of connecting values to policies—the politically knowledgeable (Zaller 1992)

Because the German and Dutch panels lack consistent measures of political knowledge, I proxy it with education and political interest (Delli Carpini and Keeter 1996). To validate these proxies, I estimated the following regressions for each value and panel:

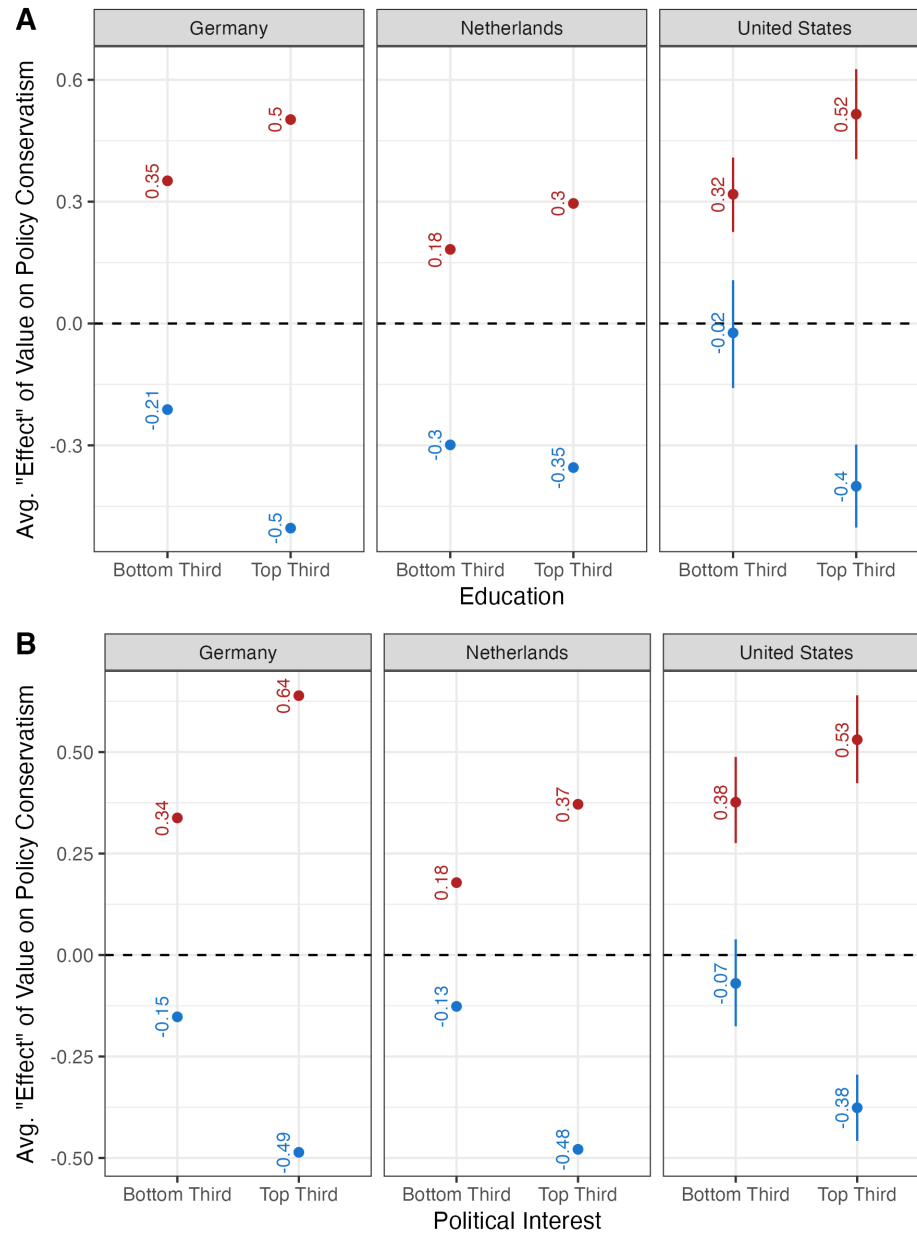
$$\begin{aligned}
 Policy_{i,p,t} = & \beta_1 * Value_i + \beta_2 * Education_{i,t} + \beta_3 * Acquiescence_i + \\
 & \beta_4 * Value_i * Education_{i,t} + \beta_5 Education_{i,t} * Acquiescence_i + \beta_6 * Value_i * Acquiescence_i \\
 & + \beta_7 * Value_i * Education_{i,t} * Acquiescence_i + \gamma_p + \lambda_t + \varepsilon_{i,p,t} \\
 Policy_{i,p,t} = & \beta_1 * Value_i + \beta_2 * Interest_{i,t} + \beta_3 * Acquiescence_i + \\
 & \beta_4 * Value_i * Interest_{i,t} + \beta_5 Interest_{i,t} * Acquiescence_i + \beta_6 * Value_i * Acquiescence_i \\
 & + \beta_7 * Value_i * Interest_{i,t} * Acquiescence_i + \gamma_p + \lambda_t + \varepsilon_{i,p,t}
 \end{aligned}$$

Policy is panelist *i*'s opinion on issue *p* at wave *t*; *Value* captures endorsement of the related value; and *Acquiescence* controls for indiscriminate agreement with value statements. *Education* and *Interest* are measured at the wave level. The models include policy-issue (γ) and wave (λ) fixed effects and are fully interacted to minimize bias (Blackwell and Olson 2022).

Figure Q1 confirms that the associational “effects” of values on policy conservatism are larger when a panelist has more education or greater political interest. In short, the more educated and politically engaged more tightly connect values to policy opinions.

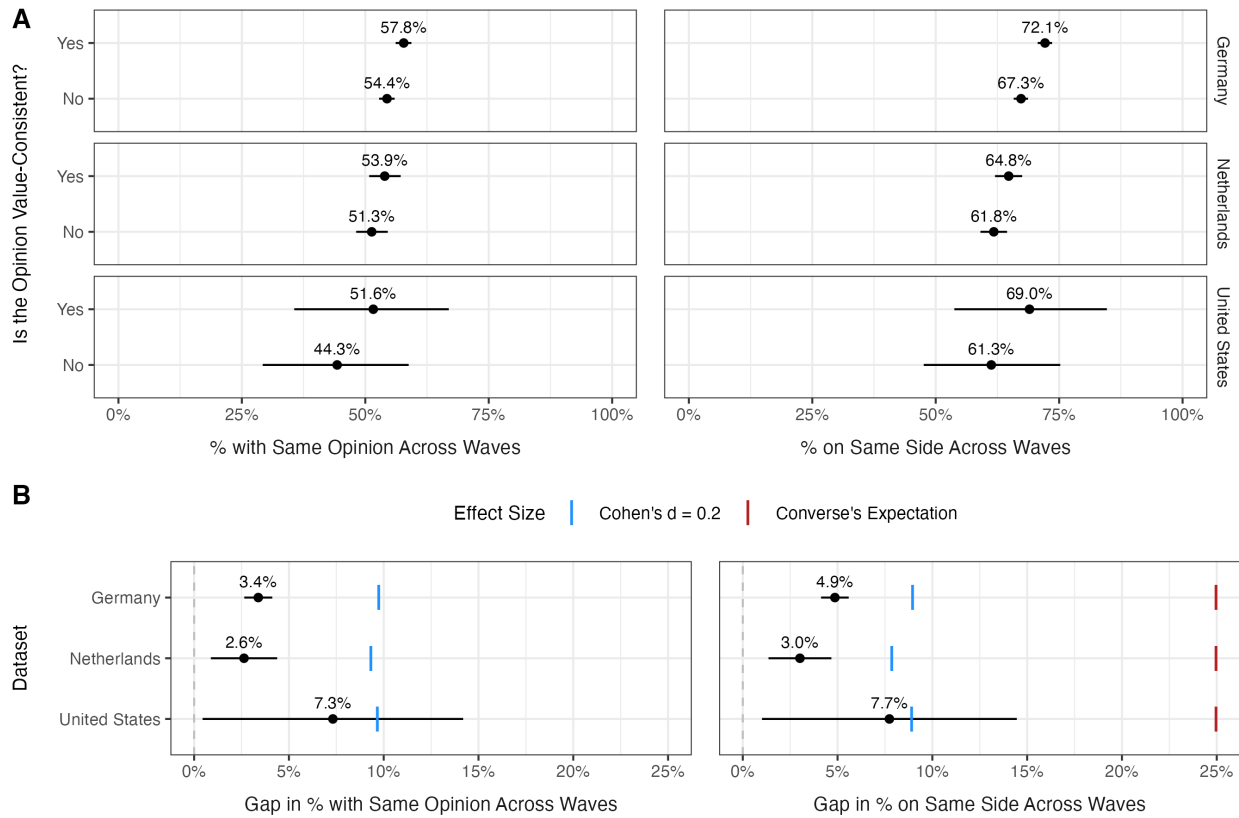
With these proxies validated, I replicate my main analyses within each high-sophistication group. Point estimates in Figure Q2 and Figure Q3 track the full-sample results, with the U.S. estimates once again losing precision.

Figure Q1: Associational “Effect” of Values on Policy Conservatism by Education and Political Interest



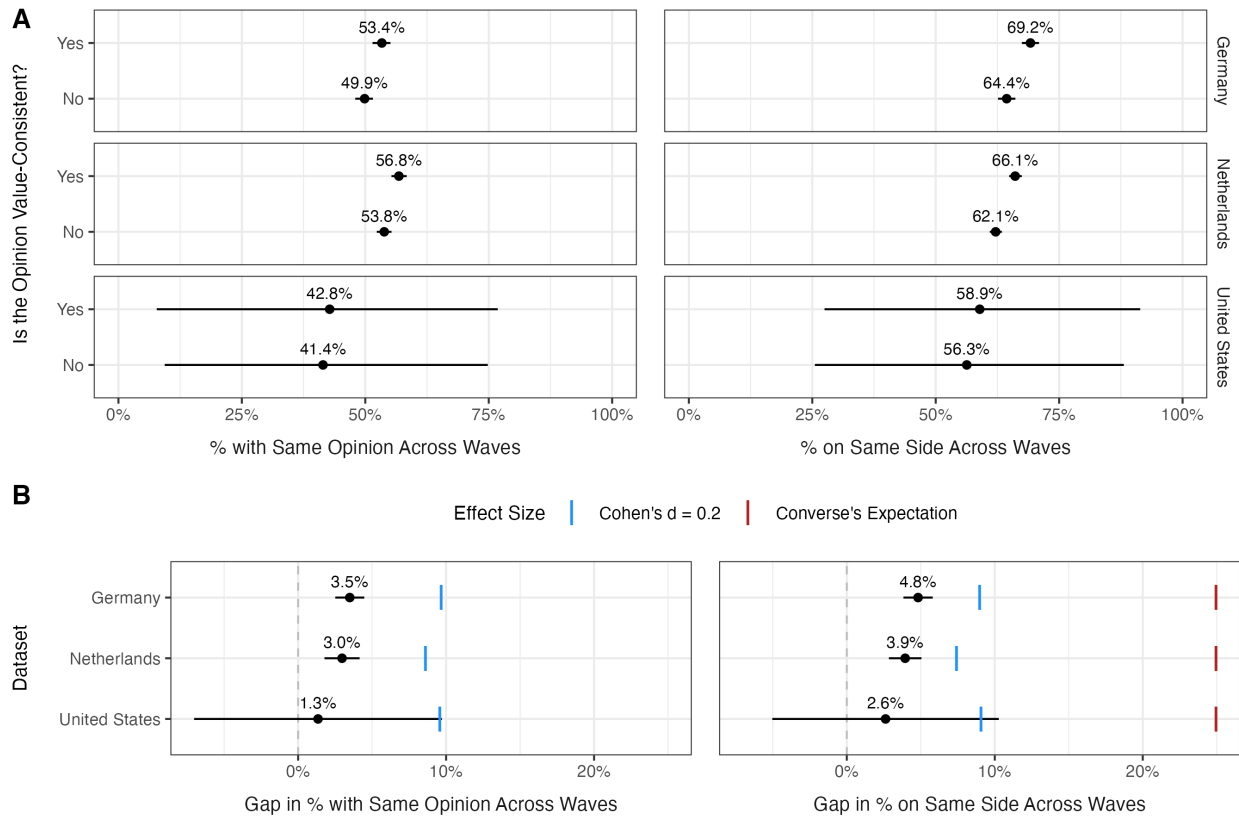
Note: Sub-figure A (B) depicts the associational “effect” of panelists’ values on policy conservatism at different levels of education (political interest). Blue points represent the effects of self-transcendence values; red points represent the effects of conservation values. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist. Data weighted to give each panelist, policy issue, and period equal weight.

Figure Q2: Results Among the Most Educated



Note: Sub-figure A shows the predicted stability of value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions. Sub-figure B visualizes the gap between these estimates alongside two benchmarks: Cohen's $d = 0.2$ and Converse's expected gap between citizens and legislators. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist. Data weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight.

Figure Q3: Results Among the Most Politically Interested



Note: Sub-figure A shows the predicted stability of value-consistent and -inconsistent opinions. Sub-figure B visualizes the gap between these estimates alongside two benchmarks: Cohen's $d = 0.2$ and Converse's expected gap between citizens and legislators. Lines represent 95% confidence intervals from wild bootstrap standard errors clustered by panelist. Data weighted to give each panelist, value-policy pair, and period equal weight.